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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

In the presence of President Ramchandra Paudel, Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha administering the oath of office and secrecy to the newly appointed justices of the Supreme Court at Presidential Building, Sheetal Niwas in Kathmandu on Thursday.

NEW JUSTICES TAKE OATH

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Newly appointed six judges of Supreme Court (SC) took an oath of office and secrecy before Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha amidst a programme here on Tuesday. They took the oath in presence of President Ramchandra Paudel at the ceremony held at the Office of the President, Shital Niwas.

The Parliamentary Hearing Committee on Wednesday endorsed the nominations of Saranga Subedi, Abdul Ajij Musalman, Mahesh Sharma Paudel, Tek Prasad Dhungana, Sunil Kumar Pokhrel and Balkrishna Dhakal as the apex court judges and it followed their appointments on the posts by the Head of the State same day.

Today's Supplement Highlight

AI: Shaping Tomorrow, Transforming Today's Reality.



Nepal, Sri Lanka discuss Lumbini-Colombo air connection

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Nepal and Sri Lanka have discussed about the possible air connections between Colombo and Lumbini.

The first meeting of Nepal-Sri Lanka Joint Commission (JC) that began in Kathmandu on Thursday take a note that the start of Kathmandu-Colombo air connection was encouraging and talked about further cooperation in aviation and other sectors, informed the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) of Nepal.

Nepal is looking for options to bring in Buddhist pilgrims and tourists directly to Lumbini, the birthplace of Lord Buddha, through the Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa. However, formal discussions are being made with China, Myanmar, Thailand and Sri Lanka in the first phase.

Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, NP Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart, M. U. M. Ali Sabry are leading the delegation of their country to the meeting that will run untill Friday. The Sri Lankan delegation led by its Foreign Minister Sabry arrived Kathmandu on Wednesday.

Two Ministers shared about the serious impacts of climate change faced by the respective country. They emphasized the need of climate justice, early operationalization of loss and damage fund, and more international support to combat the impacts of climate change in countries like Nepal and Sri Lanka.

The two countries also signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Cooperation in the Field of Science, Technology and Innovation. The Ministry of Education, Science and Technology of Nepal and the Ministry of Education of Sri Lanka signed and exchanged the MoU at the meeting.

Likewise, the two ministers exchanged thoughts on the possibility of transferring the three Nepali nationals imprisoned in Sri Lanka. They also discussed about the exchanges in culture, tourism and education sectors, regional cooperation including strengthening SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) and BIMSTEC processes, and cooperation in multilateral forums.

Nepali delegation to the meeting includes Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal, Ambassador of Nepal to Sri Lanka Basudev Mishra, and senior officials from ministries of Commerce, Home and Foreign Affairs.

Sri Lanka delegation includes Ambassador of Sri Lanka in Kathmandu Sudarshana Pathirana and senior officials of their Foreign Ministry.

Earlier today, Foreign Minister of Sri Lanka paid a courtesy call on Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at his office in Singha Durbar. On the occasion, discussions were held on matters of mutual interest between Nepal and Sri Lanka, the MoFA said in a statement.

During the visit, the Minister Sabry is also scheduled to pay courtesy calls on President of Nepal, Ramchandra Poudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, the MoFA said.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart M. U. M. Ali Sabry holding a bilateral talk in Kathmnadu on Thursday.

Scrap licenses held without initiating project work: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation to scrap the licenses of those who hold them for hydropower projects but do not proceed ahead the works.

Speaking at a joint review meeting of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation and Ministry of Communication and Information Technology held at the Office of the Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda gave this instruction.

The Prime Minister said, "The practice of carrying a river in bags has been in news headlines for a long time. Taking a license and holding it but not working is suicidal for the country. We do not have to be flexible. Such licenses should be scrapped by creating certain criteria."

"The tax system should be organised by cutting the electricity lines of the big ones who do not pay electricity dues," said PM Prachanda, "Do not compromise with anyone. Let's immediately disconnect the lines of non-paying dedicated and trunk lines. Start with the big ones and go towards collecting all the tariff dues."

He said that an irrigation system is necessary for production increase, and we should also think about lift irrigation.

"We should think about long-term management of irrigation by connecting the river system," said the Prime Minister, adding, "The problem of irrigation is also deeply connected with agriculture. Let's do the necessary homework in this direction to increase the productivity of agriculture."

"One year has passed since the formation of the present government under my leadership, next year, we are going in a new way," he said, "For that, let's change our thinking, let's change the way we work."

"I am serious about listening to the ministry, understanding and producing better results. I am changing the way of working, think about what you will do for the country and the people and move forward with determination. As we continue to do good, those with evil intentions are exposed. Let's do it that way."

In the meeting, Prime Minister Prachanda instructed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology to simplify the policy related to advertising and to think about protecting the communication industry when

» SEE PAGE 6

Castes with less than 0.5% population to be listed as minorities

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The government has decided that the castes whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population will be classified as minorities.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Thursday in Singha Durbar designated the minority castes for Clause (b) of Section 2 of the National Assembly Member Election Act 2019.

Talking to the media after the Cabinet meeting, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said, "The meeting has decided that each caste whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population as per the National Census-2021 will be listed as minorities."

Minister Sharma, who is also the government Spokesperson said, "Castes belonging to the Dalit community will not be included in such list."

The meeting also decided to approve the guidelines for the use of social media by government offices-2023 submitted by the social committee of the Cabinet and approved the national policy for persons with disabilities.

Similarly, the meeting also approved the National Children's Policy-2022.

Meanwhile, as per the Cabinet decision, the government has released Rs. 10 million to provide compensation of Rs. 1 million each to 10 individuals who got killed during the Hamas attack in Israel on October 7 this year.

Deuba urges party workers to make NC victorious in next election

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpurdham, Dec. 21



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has urged the party rank and file to work in such a way that the party will be victorious by securing a majority in the next election.

Inaugurating the first conference of the party's Madhes Province in Janakpurdham on Thursday, Deuba urged the party's Madhes Committee to work to win majority seats in the next poll.

NC general secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa said the NC need not to fear with anyone as theirs was the largest party in the Federal Parliament and a party that had promulgated the constitution.

He underlined the need for giving more opportunity to women, Dalits and Muslims by increasing their participation in the party.

Stressing the need for warning the leaders who abused the electoral system, Thapa said that NC should fulfill the duty of maintaining good governance as the party was leading 332 local governments.

He urged the party leadership to look at history. "There are evidences that BP Koirala succeeded to perform works within 24 months which had not been done before in 200 years. If the NC works in the provinces and local levels where it is leading the governments without any discrimination and without involving in corruption, the party will win the next elections," he said. He also urged the party leaders to maintain unity in the party.

NC joint general secretary Mahendra Yadav said that federalism would become weak if NC became weak.

Urging to strength the NC to strengthen the federalism, Yadav urged the Chief Minister of Madhes to perform as per the spirit of the coalition.

In the conference held under the chairmanship of NC Madhes Province Committee chair Krishna Prasad Yadav, NC vice president and Deputy Prime Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka and others also aired their views.

No functional hospitals left in northern Gaza: WHO

AFP
Geneva, Dec. 21

There are no longer any functional hospitals in the north of the Gaza Strip, the World Health Organization said Thursday, describing "unbearable" scenes of largely abandoned patients begging for food and water.

The UN health agency said it had led missions to two badly damaged hospitals, Al-Shifa and Al-Ahli, in the north of the Palestinian territory on Wednesday.

"Our staff are running out of words to describe the beyond catastrophic situation facing remaining patients and health workers," said Richard Peeperkorn, the WHO representative for the occupied Palestinian territory.

His comment came amid increasingly frantic diplomatic efforts to secure a pause in the war that Hamas says has already claimed 20,000 lives in Gaza, 70 percent of them women and children.

The war began when Hamas attacked Israel on October 7, killing around 1,140 people, mostly civilians, and abducting about 250, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

WHO has already described Al-Shifa, the largest hospital in Gaza which last month was the focus of an extended Israeli army operation and has been devastated by Israeli bombardments, as "a blood bath".

> There are no operating theatres anymore due to the lack of fuel, power, medical supplies and health workers, including surgeons and other specialists.

The smaller Al-Ahli hospital had since become the only place where surgeries were possible in the north, but its director said it had stopped operating on Tuesday after being stormed by the Israeli army.

- Dying 'slowly and painfully' -

The WHO-led mission revealed that Al Ahli, which just two days ago was "overwhelmed with patients needing emergency care", was now "a shell of a hospital", Peeperkorn told reporters in Geneva via video link from Jerusalem.

"There are no operating theatres anymore due to the lack of fuel, power, medical supplies and health workers, including surgeons and other specialists," he added.

"It has completely stopped functioning."

Of Gaza's original 36 hospitals, only nine are now partially functional, all of them in the south.

"There are no functional hospitals left in the north."

Hospitals, protected under international humanitarian law, have repeatedly been hit by Israeli strikes in Gaza since the war erupted.

The Israeli military accuses Hamas of having tunnels under hospitals and using the medical facilities as command centres, a charge denied by the Islamist group.

Asked about the charge, Peeperkorn said "we on our missions have not seen anything of this on the ground", adding that WHO was "not in a position to assert how any hospital is being used".

Although Wednesday's mission had aimed to deliver fuel, he said, the lack of security guarantees had meant they could only deliver medical supplies and medicines.

But that was not enough, he said.

"Without fuel, staff, and other essential needs, medicines won't make a difference and all patients will die slowly and painfully."

Al Ahli, he said, still counts around 10 staff striving to provide basic first aid, while around 80 patients are sheltering in a church within the hospital grounds and the orthopaedic section.

- 'Too late' -

Sean Casey, a WHO Emergency Medical Teams coordinator who was on the mission, described "unbelievable conditions".

At Al Ahli, the team had walked through the courtyard, where bodies wrapped in white plastic sheeting piled up, and with automatic gunfire sounding nearby, he told journalists, speaking from Rafah in southern Gaza.

In the church, "we found a really unbearable scene," Casey said, describing around 30 patients, including young children and some with serious trauma wounds begging, not for care but for water.

"At the moment, it is a place where people are waiting to die."

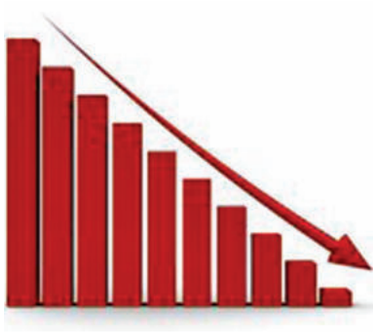
He reiterated the increasingly urgent call for a ceasefire to allow sufficient amounts of aid in and also to evacuate more patients from Gaza.

Asked when whether time was running out, he said: "I think it is (already) too late.

"We are dealing with starving adults, children... Everywhere we go, people are asking us for food," he said.

"Even in the hospitals, ... people with open, bleeding fractures, they ask for food.

NEPSE shows double digit correction



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The stock market index NEPSE, which has been increasing for seven consecutive days since Tuesday last week, showed a double-digit correction on Thursday.

The NEPSE index declined by 32.77 points (1.53 per cent) to close at 2,109.10 points on Thursday, the last trading day of the week.

NEPSE index increased by 193.27 points during the last seven days' transaction.

Along with the decline in the NEPSE index, the transaction amount also fell today.

A total of 17,172,149 shares worth Rs. 6.27 billion of 304 companies were sold in 111,980 transactions today.

Earlier on Wednesday, shares worth Rs. 7.95 billion were traded.

The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies declined by 6 points (1.49 per cent) to close at 396.62 points.

According to the Nepal Stock Exchange, sub-indices of all groups except manufacturing, processing and trading group have decreased.

Sub-index of life insurance recorded the highest fall of 329.05 points followed by the hotels and tourism and development bank group whose indices decreased by 178.61 points and 135.16 points respectively.

Similarly, the sub-index of the non-life insurance group decreased by 82.20 points, the microfinance group decreased by 78.13 points, finance by 58.36 points, banking by 23.43 points and others by 23.19 points.

Similarly, the sub-index of hydropower decreased by 7.93 points, mutual fund by 0.27 points and investment by 1.35 points.

However, the sub-index of the manufacturing and processing group posted a growth of 142 points and trading of 17.33 points in today's transaction.

The share price of Surya Jyoti Life Insurance Company decreased by 7.44 per cent, Unnati Sahakarya Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha by 7.26 per cent Sunrise First Mutual Fund by 6.94 per cent.

However, the share price of five companies, including Bottlers Nepal (Balaju) Limited, Asha Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha, Dhaulagiri Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha, BPW Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha and Chirkhwa Hydropower Limited increased by 10 per cent.

Super Seeder machine reducing cost and labour

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Inaruwa, Dec. 21

New technology has been used to sow wheat seeds in Gadhi Rural Municipality and Dewanganj Rural Municipality in Sunsari.

After the Super Seeder machine arrived in the village, it has helped mechanise wheat farming.

The farmers said the machine made farming easier and cheaper. The Super Seeder machine is expected to reduce cost and increase production by 25 per cent.

Under the wheat crop promotion programme supported by Nepal Agricultural Research Council and Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Sunsari, wheat has been planted in 10 kattha of land by using the machine in Chittaha of Gadhi Rural Municipality-4 in Sunsari,

On the occasion, member of Koshi Provincial Assembly Ramdev Yadav said that it was necessary to bring this technology within the reach of all farmers.

Neel Kamal Singh, Chief of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, said that the wheat planting programme has been done in 10 kattha of land by using a Super Seeder machine in Dewanganj Rural Municipality-4 Kaptanganj.

According to Singh, NL 971 varieties of wheat have been planted in the 10 kattha of land of local farmer Ramdev Mehta.

With this technology, it is easy to sow, apply fertiliser, plough and thresh at the same time, saving time and labour.

In the programme held in Dewanganj Rural Municipality-4 Kaptangunj, Chairman of Municipality Bechan Prasad Mehta said that the farmers have been benefited from the technology.



PHOTO: TRN

Farmers are posing for photos in front of Super Seeder machine at Sunsari.

SKorean court orders Japanese firms to compensate more wartime Korean workers

AP
Seoul, Dec. 21

South Korea's top court ordered two Japanese companies to financially compensate more of their wartime Korean workers for forced labour, as it sided Thursday with its contentious 2018 verdicts on the firms that caused a huge setback in relations between the Asian neighbours.

But observers said that Thursday's ruling won't likely hurt bilateral ties much since Seoul and Tokyo, now governed by different leaders, are pushing hard to bolster their partnerships in the face of shared challenges like North Korea's evolving nuclear threats and China's increasing assertiveness.

The Supreme Court ruled that Mitsubishi Heavy Industries must provide between 100 million and 150 million won ($76,700 and $115,000) in compensation to each of four plaintiffs — all bereaved families of its former employees who were forced to work for the company during Japan's 1910-45 colonial rule of the Korean Peninsula. The court also said Nippon Steel Corp. must give 100 million won (about $76,700) to each of seven Korean plaintiffs, also all bereaved relatives, for similar colonial-era forced labour.

"I felt so sad when I heard the name of (my father) being stated as the deceased at today's trial, but I was still really glad that we won — though it's a bit late," said Joo Soon-ja, daughter of the late Joo Seok-bong, a forced labourer, as she held her father's large framed photo.

In two separate verdicts in 2018, the top South Korean court ordered Mitsubishi and Nippon Steel to compensate a total of 15 other Korean employees for forced labour. That irked Japan, which has insisted all compensation issues were already settled by a 1965 bilateral treaty that normalized their diplomatic relations. But the 2018 South Korean court rulings said that the treaty can't prevent individuals from seeking compensation for forced labour, because Japanese companies' use of such labourers were "acts of illegality against humanity" that were linked to Tokyo's illegal colonial occupation and its war of aggression.

In Thursday's ruling, the South Korean Supreme Court cited that argument in one of the 2018 verdicts, saying it paved the way for "a judicial remedy for forced labour victims within Republic of Korea." Japan's chief Cabinet secretary, Yoshi masa Hayashi, called the ruling "absolutely unacceptable," saying it clearly violated the 1965 treaty.

The wrangling touched off by the 2018 rulings led to the two countries downgrading each other's trade status, and Seoul's previous liberal government threatening to spike a military intelligence-sharing pact. Their strained ties complicated efforts by the United States to build a stronger trilateral Washington-Seoul-Tokyo cooperation to counter challenges posed by North Korea and China.

The Seoul-Tokyo relations, however, began thawing after South Korea's current conservative president, Yoon Suk Yeol, announced in March that his country would use a local corporate fund to compensate forced labour victims without demanding Japanese contributions. Japanese Prime Minister Fumio Kishida later expressed sympathy for the suffering of Korean forced laborers during a Seoul visit. The two countries revived high-level talks and withdrew economic retaliatory steps against each other.

On Thursday, the two countries held their first high-level economic talks in Seoul in about eight years and agreed to work together to realize substantial cooperation on economic sectors based on improving ties, according to South Korea's Foreign Ministry.

Eleven of the 15 former forced labourers or their families involved in the 2018 rulings had accepted compensation under Seoul's third-party reimbursement plan, but the remaining four still refuse to accept it, according to Lee Kook Un, a leader of their support group.

GLOBAL IME BANK WINS 'PAYMENTS EXCELLENCE AWARDS 2023'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Global IME Bank Limited has received the 'Payments Excellence Awards 2023' from VISA, a global leader in digital payment technology. The bank was honoured for its excellence in Debit Cards in 2023.

The award was presented at the 'Leadership Conclave Nepal 2023' conference organised by VISA in Kathmandu.

The bank has recently launched a special digital payment product, 'Scan to Pay,' in collaboration with VISA.

GIBL is the first commercial bank from the private sector to have branches in all 77 nation districts.

Additionally, it holds a leading position among banks with the maximum number of outlets worldwide from Nepal.

The bank provides digital financial services across the country through its 355 branches, 379 ATMs, 274 branchless banking units, 65 Extension Counters (including revenue collection counters), and three foreign representative offices, bringing the total number of outlets to more than 1,100.

These outlets cater to over 4.5 million customers, offering complete and fully-fledged digital banking services.

Galyang farmers become happy when agriculture technicians reach their farms

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Dec. 21

After the agricultural and livestock technicians of Galyang Municipality reached the farmers' fields, the farmers were excited.

Under the 'Agricultural Technical Programme with Farmers' conducted by the Municipality, the technicians reached the farms.

Mayor of Galyang Municipality Guru Prasad Bhattarai said that 4,187 farmers benefited from the two-month programme conducted by the municipality.

He said that the programme based on the demand and needs of the farmers has benefited the subsistence farmers as well as the commercial farmers.

The farmers of the municipality are also happy after getting the technicians in the field.

Gomata Gaha, a farmer of Galyang Municipality-8, said that due to small problems, they have to abandon farming.

"We have reached a situation where we stop farming because we cannot solve small problems regarding farming.

A little advice adds enthusiasm to farming. Farmers were happy after getting the technicians in their place," Gaha said.

According to the municipality, the technicians have reached 61 villages in the municipality, which has 11 wards.

Mayor Bhattarai said that the programme was run with the plan to connect general farmers in the villages with the service facilities of the agriculture and livestock department of the municipality and to support farmers who lack access to the service facilities provided by the agriculture and livestock department of the municipality.

He said, "We started the programme after only a limited number of people have access to the agricultural programme schemes, the municipality's efforts are to reach the subsistence, poor and lower-class farmers and connect them to production."

Chief Administrative Officer of the municipality Damodar Sharma said that 68 per cent of farmers' households have benefited from the programme.

According to him, they have received information related to agricultural consultation and interacted with the technicians on agriculture and animal husbandry.

He said that 73.8 per cent of women, 48 per cent of indigenous and 3 per cent of Dalit community farmers have been benefited from the programme.

More US auto buyers are turning to hybrids

AP
Detroit, Dec. 21

America's automakers have staked their futures on the notion that electric vehicles will dominate sales in the coming years, spurred by buyers determined to reduce carbon emissions and save on fuel.

But so far, while EV sales are growing, their pace is falling well short of the industry's ambitious timetable for transitioning away from combustion engines. Instead, buyers are increasingly embracing a quarter-century-old technology whose popularity has been surging: The gas-electric hybrid, which alternates from gas to battery power to maximize efficiency.

So far in 2023, Americans have bought a record 1 million-plus hybrids — up 76% from the same period last year, according to Edmunds.com. As recently as last year, purchases had fallen below 2021's total. This year's figures don't even include sales of 148,000 plug-in hybrids, which drive a short distance on battery power before a gas-electric system kicks in.

Though electric vehicle sales are nearing an annual record of over 1 million this year, their year-over-year growth rate has begun to stall. EVs still account for only about 7% of all U.S. auto sales. The slowdown has raised concern among automakers that buyer interest in EVs is faltering. Some companies are cutting production and scaling down plans for new battery or assembly plants.

The reasons why hybrids have quickly become the preferred choice for many buyers vary. They range from the higher prices of comparable EVs to concern about the scarcity of charging stations to a recognition that hybrids provide many of the same advantages without the hassles of EVs.

Ford, the nation's No. 2 hybrid seller behind Toyota, expects to produce enough hybrids to quadruple sales within five years. General Motors, which abandoned most hybrids in the U.S. four years ago in favor of EVs, now says it's considering bringing them back.

In the meantime, surveys show that consumers remain uneasy about either the availability of charging stations or the sale prices of EVs — even factoring in tax credits that the federal government makes available for EV purchases in many cases.

"Your standard hybrid makes the most sense to most people," said Ivan Drury, a director at the Edmunds.com auto website. "I think you'll find that people don't want to deal with the hassle or the difficulties of charging."



Hybrids do emit some tailpipe pollution. But because they burn less fuel than autos equipped solely with gasoline engines, their emissions are less. What's more, purchase prices for hybrids are akin to those of gas vehicles and typically far less than for comparable EVs. "People are perfectly fine with a car that gets 45 or 50 miles per gallon, and you don't have to do anything" different from current behavior, said Scott Adams, owner of a Toyota dealership in suburban Kansas City.

Here are some key reasons why hybrids, which use both a gas engine and battery power to efficiently turn the wheels, have taken off this year:

The proliferation of wildfires, heat waves and more intense storms has led more people to view climate change as a grave crisis, one they can help mitigate by burning less carbon-spewing fuel. Yet even among those people, some remain skeptical that an electric vehicle will allow them to travel long distances or tow trailers.

"People want to participate in this — the idea of reducing carbon," said Jack Hollis, who heads North American sales and marketing for Toyota, which leads in hybrid sales and has moved only gradually toward EVs. "I think the hybrid gives them what they're most looking for."

EV prices have being dropping, mainly a consequence of federal tax credits and price cuts by Tesla, the market leader. Yet they're still pricier than hybrids or gas vehicles

After peaking at nearly $63,000 last year, the average EV sale price fell to just over $60,500 in November, not including tax credits or prices from Tesla, which doesn't release them. Fewer EVs, though, will likely qualify for the tax credits in 2024 because of rules that will limit buyers from claiming a full credit if they purchase cars with battery materials from China or other countries that are considered hostile to the United States.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 119000	▲
Worked Gold	: Rs. 118450	▲
Silver	: Rs. 1480	▲

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,109.10	▼
Total Amount	: 6,274,324,811.9	▼
No. of Share	: 17,172,149	▼

DALITS OF JIRIKHIMTI COMPLAIN OF EXCLUSION

BY HARI PRASAD KOIRALA
Urlabari, Dec. 21

Dalit communities in Jirikhimti of Pathari Shanishchare Municpality-10, Morang, have decided to fight against caste discrimination stating that they were deliberately excluded from ceremonies like marriage, puja and other rituals.

At a joint press meeting on Monday, Bishwakarma Ekata Samaj, Nepal Dalit Sangh, Utpidit Mukti Samaj, Nepal Dalit Liberation Front and Dalit Liberation Organisation of Nepal informed about the formation of a struggle committee under the coordination of Gopal Lakandri (Bishwakarma).

According to the leaders of the Dalit community, Rita Diyali, a Dalit, was not allowed to perform puja during a Bhagwat Saptaha organised on May 20 by Punya Prasad Subedi of Jirikhimti. After that, the local police arrived at the site to arrest Subedi. However, Subedi was not arrested on the same day as he agreed to apologise to the Diyali family after the conclusion of the Saptaha.

Shantadevi Subebi, 72, is now facing legal action due to a case filed against her.

After the incident, Dalits were deliberately not invited to weddings and other religious ceremonies. Jirikhimti has a total of 300 households, with 26 belonging to Dalit.

During the press meet, the Dalit community leaders accused upper caste people of not inviting them to any ceremonies. However, the accused refuted the claim stating, "We have invited limited people due to budget constraints and we have not purposefully excluded Dalits."

Karnali Provincial Hospital introduces online OPD tickets

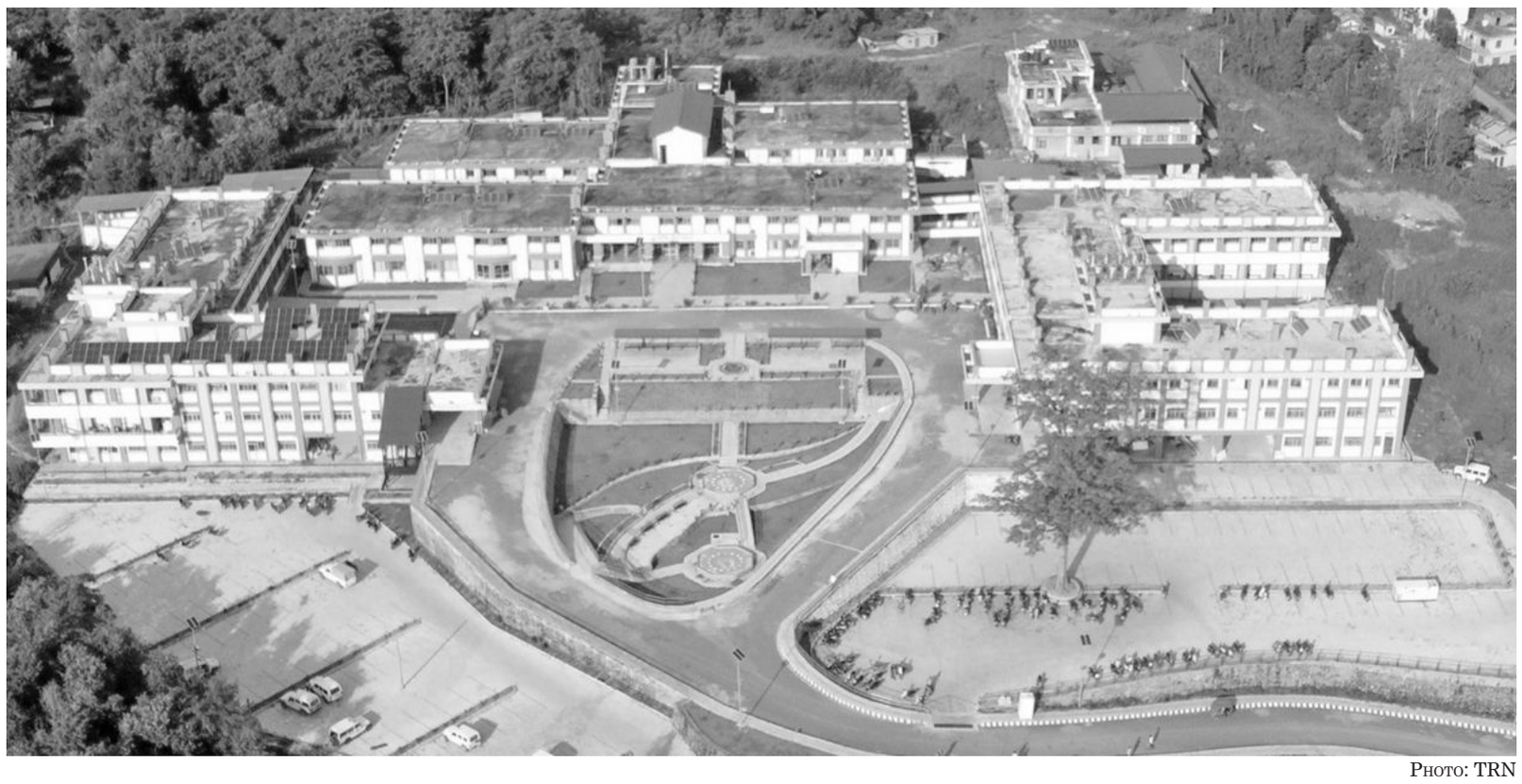


PHOTO: TRN

Karnali Provincial Hospital in Surkhet.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Dec. 21

With the increasing inflow of patients, the Karnali Provincial Hospital in Surkhet has introduced online booking system for OPD patients.

Prof. Dr. Dambar Khadka, Director of Karnali Provincial Hospital, informed that from now on people do not need to stand in long queues in the morning for doctor's appointments. "We need to inform and educate people about the online system," he added.

Khadka said that people should first register online. "On the website, the patients can select the doctors, date and appointment time. Then, people have to fill in a brief form and book an appointment. People can bring the print copy or screenshot of the doctor's appointment to receive the service," added Khadka.

The online system would make it easier for people to book appointments with their preferred doctor at an appropriate time. This process will help manage the crowd of patients in the hospital.

FIVE DIE IN TRACTOR ACCIDENT IN RUKUM WEST

RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum West, Dec. 21

Five persons were killed on the spot and nine others were injured in a tractor accident in Aathbiskot Municipality-10 in Rukum West on Wednesday night.

Police Inspector Dharmendra Khadka of the District Police Office said that the tractor with registration number RA 1 Ta 14, loaded with zinc sheets for the construction of temporary shelters for the earthquake victims met with an accident at 10:15 pm when it was heading to Gharti village from Radi of Aathbiskot Municipality-9.

Khadka said the deceased have been identified as Lok Bahadur Shahi, 46, and his wife Chuki Shahi, 42; Bhardar Sarki, 52; Dhanaraj Sarki, 48, and Nirmala Sarki, 47.

After collecting from the accident site, the bodies were kept at the Municipal Hospital for further legal procedure, said Inspector Khadka.

In the accident, Ramesh Sarki, 38, of Aathbiskot Municipality-10; Khadka Bahadur Pun, 41; Dal Bahadur Pun, 14; Kumar Gharti, 45; Rama Gurung, 34, and Jaga Bir Sarki, 51, were injured.

Similarly, 36-year-old Jaya Bahadur Gharti of Ward No. 8, Mane Sarki, 58, and Madan Pun, 42, were injured. All the injured persons were receiving treatment in the Municipal Hospital, Aathbiskot. Among the injured, the condition of three persons is reported critical, according to the hospital.

In the accident, the tractor fell off some 30 metres down the road in a turning. Police have arrested tractor driver Gopal B.K., 21, of Aathbiskot Municipality-9.

Process to run Shailaja Acharya Heart Disease Centre begins

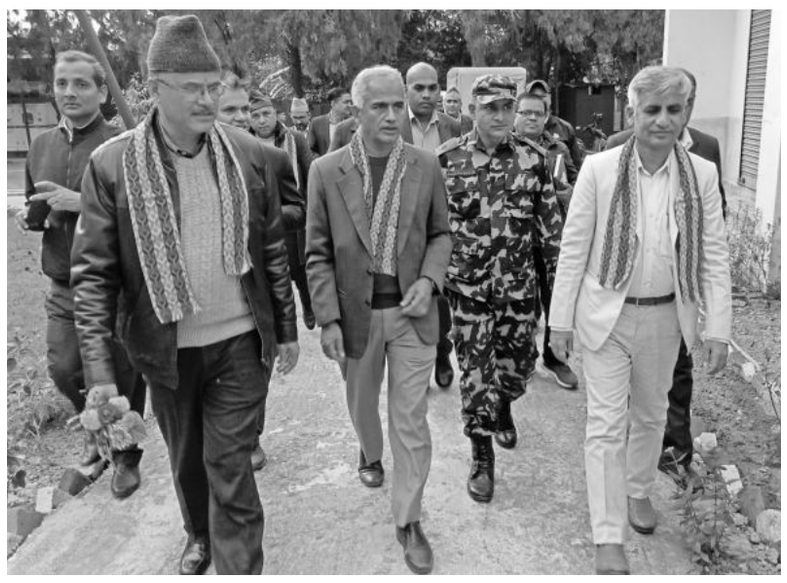


PHOTO: TRN

The Koshi Provincial Government Chife Minister Kedar Karki along with other persons concerned inspecting the area, Thursday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 21

The Koshi Provincial Government has started the necessary steps to bring the Shailaja Acharya Heart Disease Centre in Biratnagar into operation.

The provincial government led by Chief Minister Kedar Karki has allocated sufficient budget to convert the Infectious Diseases and Intensive Care Centre in Biratnagar into Shailaja Acharya Heart Disease Centre in its replacement budget of the current fiscal year.

A team including Dr. Bhupendra Basnet, Vice-Chancellor of NAMS, Dr. Lochan Karki, Dr. Anil Bikram Karki, President of Nepal Medical Association, Dr. Bhagawan Koirala and Dr. Bikrant Dhakal observed the centre and gave advises for its operation. The team studied the model of operation by identifying its capacity.

Dr. Koirala informed that a physical study was done on the hospital's building, equipment, manpower, laws, regulations and guidelines. Earlier, the hospital was operated by the Provincial Government during the COVID-19 pandemic.

The Infectious Disease and Intensive Care Centre has 44 ICU beds, 47 HDUs and 81 general beds. Other available services include ECG, X-ray, two oxygen plants of 150 cylinders, and a waste management system. The OPD service is currently operational in the centre.

Dr. Koirala said that available infrastructures, medical equipment, and public health laboratory in the Infectious Diseases and Intensive Care Centre would be used by the Heart Disease Centre, making some upgrades.

Kedar Karki, Chief Minister of Koshi Province, who is also looking after the portfolio of the Ministry of Health, said that the medical equipment at the ICU has been out of operation for a long time. "The heart centre having medical experts and high-quality equipment will provide services to the patients of the Koshi Province," added Karki.

Poudel's quest for justice against torture continues

BY NABIN SHAHI
Surkhet, Dec. 21

The memory of the physical torture Purna Prasad Poudel underwent during the decade-long conflict still haunts him.

The cracked ankles, wounds from pins gouged into his toes and scars caused by the electric shocks on his limbs persist in inflicting ongoing psychological distress upon him.

"Medicine has become my constant support. Headache and chest pain have become part of my daily routine," said Poudel, a local of Birendranagar-6, Surkhet.

"I've wandered through countless nights in a daze. I often awake abruptly, crashing into the walls of my room. Depression medication has become my guiding companion," he added.

In the year 2058 B.S., Poudel was detained by the then Royal Nepal Army. Despite being an ordinary civilian, he underwent severe physical and mental torture at the hands of the army for 18 months.

Poudel, who continues to seek justice for the torture he endured has not yet attained justice for the atrocities he suffered.

The concerned authorities such as the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, National Human Rights Commission, and the Supreme Court have already made decisions to provide him justice along with compensation.

However, even 20 years after the incident, Poudel still has to pursue the courts for the enforcement of the verdicts.

Currently, he is facing difficulties in arranging medical treatment and livelihood. "I have to seek support from my friends and family to buy my medicines and even to arrange food," he said.

"How long can I rely on others for my living?" he asked.

"My body doesn't permit me to work for a living. And there is not any support left within the family," he said.

Poudel informed that he had two sons. Following to his arrest, the army raided their home and confiscated Rs. 500,000 in cash and four tolas of gold.

"My family also endured torture. Following the incident, my 27-year-old son passed away after consuming poison. Soon after, the other son was found dead in the jungle after being missing for a few days," expressed Poudel.

"The army also seized two of my vehicles. They have not been found yet. When I inquired about my vehicles at the transportation office, they insisted on paying the tax first, citing regulations," he said.

"How am I supposed to pay taxes for my missing vehicle? And then, how can I believe that my vehicles will be recovered," Poudel said.

Poudel currently lives in a joint family comprising six members. Both he and his wife have been undergoing treatment for depression.

He mentioned that following the incident, he has been undergoing treatment by selling off all his property.

Poudel informed that he has taken a loan of Rs. 1.4 million from a commercial bank. With accumulated interest, the loan amount has now reached Rs.2.6 million.

"I used to manage paying installments regularly by borrowing money from others. But now, it has become challenging. The bank has threatened to auction the house we are now living in," he added.

In 2061 B.S., the regional office of the human rights organisation INSEC wrote a letter to the Centre for Victims of Torture (CVICT), Nepalgunj, requesting assistance for Paudel's treatment.

However, the medicine bills have not been paid according to the payment terms so far, he added.

In 2058 B.S after the victim filed a petition in the court in Surkhet, the court ordered to ascertain the facts as quickly as possible based on legal procedure, as per the applicant's claim.

When the District Administration Office, Surkhet, forwarded a recommendation to the District Public Health Office, Surkhet, to allocate relief funds in the year 2074 B.S., they requested information about whether the bills had been dispatched or not.

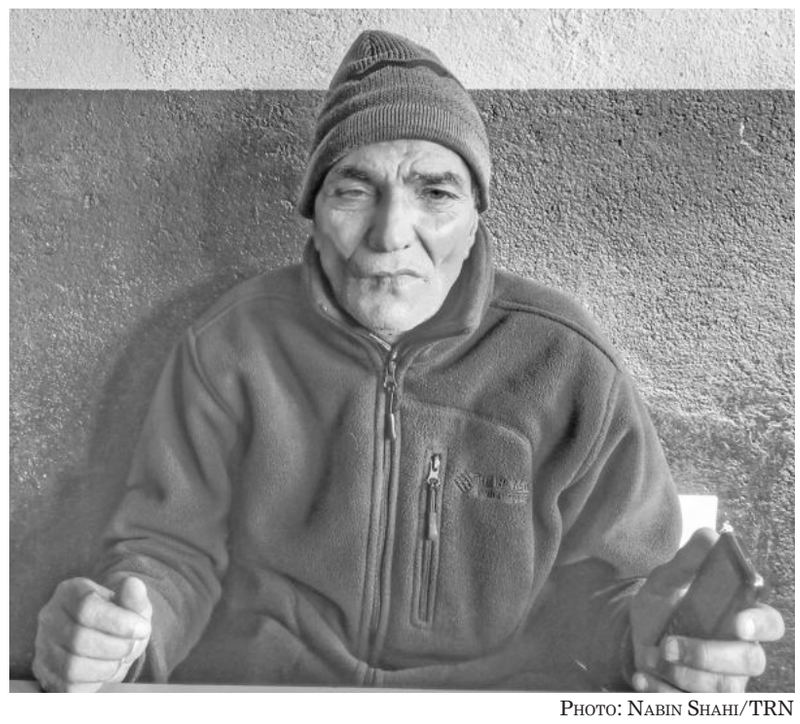


PHOTO: NABIN SHAHI/TRN

Purna Prasad Poudel.

However, the Public Health Office was unable to respond to this correspondence.

After unsuccessful attempts to attain justice previously, Poudel took the matter to the Supreme Court. The case aimed to secure compensation for relief, resolution, and legal action against the perpetrators.

The Supreme Court expedited the hearing for the mentioned petition and delivered a verdict within three months.

As per the order, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission recommended the Ministry of Home Affairs for treatment and compensation in accordance with the complaint.

Unfortunately, the recommendation for interim relief did not materialise. The initial proposal remained indecisive at the Office of the Prime Minister.

After the second detailed investigation, the cabinet meeting held on December 18, 2021, passed a decision regarding the commission's recommendation of Rs. 500,000.

Poudel continues to endure the agony of not attaining justice as per the court's verdict and the cabinet's decision, further intensifying his suffering.

He filed another case in the Supreme Court, challenging the validity of the identity card he obtained.

Poudel argued that the victim's identity outlined in the identity card obscured his true identity, failing to accurately represent him as the actual victim.

A single bench of Justice Tej Bahadur KC issued an interim order for the TRC, demanding the inclusion of the perpetrator's name, the true identity of the victim, and specific incident details before distributing the identity card, as demanded by the victims.

However, these specific details have not been included as of now.

Oil tanker knocks motorcycle rider to death

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkewar, Dec. 21

A motorcyclist died when an oil tanker hit the two-wheeler along the East-West Highway at Dharapani of Dhanushadham Municipality-9, Dhanusha. The Area Police Office, Dhalkewar, said that a petroleum tanker with registration Na 4 Kha 4152 heading west from east on Wednesday night hit the motorcycle with registration number Lu 86 Pa 8409 that was coming from the opposite direction.

In the accident, 30-year-old Saroj Kumar Mandal of Dhanushadham Municipality-9 died. Critically injured Mandal succumbed to his injuries while undergoing treatment in Provincial Hospital, Janakpur.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Project Management Directorate
Arunkhola Dumkibas 132/33 kV Substation Project
Invitation for Bid No.: NEA-PMD-ADSP-2080/81-SQ-01
Date of publication : 2080/09/06 (22nd December 2023)
(E-Bidding Only)

1. Arunkhola Dumkibas 132/33 kV Substation Project, Nepal Electricity Authority invites sealed quotations from registered contractors for the "Construction of 200/150 mm size and 120 m depth Deep Tubewell with Development and pumping test at Dumkibas Substation, Nawalparasi".
2. Interested eligible suppliers may obtain bid documents from website below and other required information at the office: The Project Manager, ADSP Site Office, Dumkibas, Nawalparasi, Nepal.

Ph no. +977 9851155752 Website: ***www.bolpatra.gov.np***

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport
Department of Roads
Mechanical Training Center, Patandhoka
Invitation for Bids
Date of publication: 2023/12/22

The Mechanical Training Centre, Patandhoka, Lalitpur invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the following construction works National Competitive Bidding – Single Stage Single Envelope Bidding procedures.

Descriptions	IFB No.	Estimated Amount (with VAT) NRs.	Minimum bid security amount, NRs.
Construction Of Equipment Parking Garage in Heavy Equipment Division, Nepalgunj	MTC/337310113/ NCB/080-81/01	9,929,387.50	240,000.00
Construction Of Equipment Parking Garage in Heavy Equipment Division, Pokhara, Kaski	MTC/337310113/ NCB/080-81/02	1,38,27,893.70	385,000.00

For more details, please visit PPMO website: www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

If you tell the truth, you don't have to remember anything.
- Mark Twain

EDITORIAL

Sweet Relief To Farmers

To the relief of sugarcane farmers, the government has fixed the minimum support price of sugarcane at Rs. 635 per quintal for the current fiscal year 2023/24, an increase of Rs. 25 per quintal from a year ago. This critical measure aims to insulate the farmers in case their produce fails to get the fair price or their investment is at stake. From mouth-savouring sweets to mark the festivals or special occasions to daily cups of beloved tea, sugar is one the main ingredients in our dishes. However, the sorry state of affairs sugarcane farmers usually find themselves in deserves discussion.

Year after year sugarcane farmers are forced to take to the streets, demanding fair and timely payment of their produce by sugar mills. They have to run from pillar to post to get sugar mills to release the money owed to them. Many of them resort to taking loans from loan sharks to purchase seeds and fertilisers. But when monsoon rains fail or come in inadequate quantity, the yield takes a negative turn. That renders them unable to earn enough to repay their loan, let alone pay for daily essentials. Making matters worse, the money, more often than not, is borrowed at exorbitant rate. Unable to pay off the loan on time has also meant they have been forced to sell their land to loan sharks at dirt cheap rate.

The minimum support price goes a long way to fetch the fair price for their produce. That will ensure they will continue getting that price even amid unfavourable circumstances. But more needs to be done to address their grievances. Failing to do that can have dire consequences. A few months ago, when the country was bracing for the season of the biggest festivals, the people were shocked to learn sugar was nowhere to be found in local market or even in supermarkets. If or when available, people had to pay ridiculously exorbitant price. The scarcity was attributed to the shortage of sugarcane to be crushed in the sugar mills. The problem still persists.

When farmers suffer, consumers also suffer. Their long-standing problems have forced them to switch to alternative crops or to stop growing sugarcane altogether – the reasons contributing to the shortfall. In a worrying trend, sugarcane production has been in decline. In the fiscal year 2019-20, the country produced 3.40 million tonnes of sugarcane, which fell to 3.18 million tonnes in 2020-21. That further dropped to 3.15 million tonnes in 2021-22. To turn the table, farmers must be incentivised with more subsidies and other support.

If measures are not rolled out soon, things are sure to get bitter in the coming months. India, the world's No. 2 sugar producer has restricted the export of sugar since October in light of the falling production, and experts say it has to begin importing sugar by 2025. This means we will no longer be able to turn to India to make up the shortfall. The farmers are saying the revised minimum support price is still not enough, demanding it should be at least Rs. 750. Not only sugarcane, but the entire agriculture sector suffers from neglect. As rising food price continues to have a negative impact in our budget, we cannot afford to sit idle and do nothing.

Fulfil Climate Pledge

BINI DAHAL

Yet another year is coming to an end. And in a situation where the world is faced with rising global warming problems, the 28th Conference of Parties (COP) concluded recently in Dubai. Under the chairmanship of the United Arab Emirates (UAE), the important summit took place from November 30 to December 12, 2023 where representatives from around 200 countries attended. The summit is said to be the first where countries agreed that fossil fuel was the main cause behind rising global warming. They have also come to an understanding to reduce the global consumption of fossil fuels considerably so as to prevent global warming.

According to the United Nations (UN), fossil fuel, which includes coal, gas and oil, is considered to be the highest contributor to climate change. Apparently, such fuels are responsible for more than 75 per cent of global greenhouse emissions and nearly 90 per cent of carbon dioxide emissions. The figures themselves speak volumes of how dangerous fossil fuels are for the mankind. Countries from around the globe have already realised the need to limit the world temperature within the threshold of 1.5 degrees Celsius.

During COP28, the global stocktake was high on agenda. The global stocktake is mainly responsible for determining the world's progress towards climate change mitigation since the Paris Agreement of 2015. But sadly, we are way behind in this connection. A total of 118 nations have signed the pledge to double global energy efficiency and triple renewable energy capacity by 2023. These have to be transformed into actions as the climate situation is turning worse from bad for many countries.

An Island nation Tuvalu, located in Oceania, has just amended its constitution so that the country can facilitate the idea of a digital nation. The reason: the country is said to be on the verge of disappearance from the world map due to climate change effects. Tuvalu is just one of many island nations that are in a vulnerable state. For a nation full of mountains and rivers, Nepal too is not safe in this. The visit of UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres to the country before the summit, gave it prominence in the global arena. So, it was in COP28 where Nepal got to take centre stage and explain how climate change was affecting the Himalaya nation.

When it comes to the growing climate change triggering global warming, developed countries must not be selfish and ignorant of the problems faced by the developing ones. The pleas of the vulnerable countries should be heard. As long as statements are not converted into implementable actions, it is quite impossible for us to keep the global temperature under the 1.5 degrees Celsius threshold as agreed to in the Paris Agreement. And not being serious about and able to control the current situation means we are headed towards doom. What kind of world will be created for the future generations when the present generations themselves are unable to survive in a healthy and good world environment?

Climate is interconnected and interwoven with the lives of people globally. Human activities have already caused excess damage to the environment and Mother Earth. Rapid and immediate actions are the only way to prevent more hazardous mishaps from happening. While a high-level meeting like that of COP can indeed give the world an overview of climate change, they will be futile if we do not take concrete steps at local, national, regional and global levels to deal with such a burning issue.

Quake Victims Need Instant Relief

Lok Deep Thapa



It is really heart-wrenching to read media reports of how the people are suffering in the recently quake-hit places of Jajarkot and West Rukum. When many people feel the bitter cold while even staying at their homes with warm clothing, it can be imagined how the unfortunate victims who have lost their homes are facing the harsh weather conditions in the quake affected areas.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda showed his concern when he visited the quake-hit areas hours after the tragedy occurred and several of his ministers did the same. He also gave directives to the ministries concerned about how they must help the victims. But the government mechanism is slow and in spite of the concern showed, it takes time for the government to implement what it has decided on. However, the people there need immediate succour and proper shelter, food and clothing to get through this tragic incident.

Distressing news

Meanwhile, the weather forecasting division has given more distressing news of how the period would become colder in the days to come. Most people know that the period between November and end of January are the coldest times in the country. So, one can imagine the problems of the people while trying to save not only from hunger but also the cold climate. It may be futile to say that Jajarkot and Rukum West are some of the remotest parts of the country and reaching these places is difficult.

The Rising Nepal has published several reports about the difficult situation the poor people in the quake-hit areas are facing. In one report it has also mentioned that the elderly, women and children are the worst affected and more than two dozen individual have died because of the cold climate. Other media outlets have also vividly described the distress the people are facing in the areas. One popular TV channel showed the devastating scenario of mostly destroyed houses and the difficulties of mostly elderly people and also the younger generation who have lost their close family members when the earthquake hit some of the worst-affected villages.

"I cannot sleep or even eat when I think of the near and dear ones of mine who died during the quake," one victim shares his agony. So this is a time when not only houses have to be rebuilt but also some sort of mental support that has to be given to these suffering people. This author would once more like to repeat that the cumbersome official process makes it difficult to provide instant assistance. Here one must mention the good work of the security forces in rescuing many individuals as soon as possible. So is the effort of the government, which just released billions of rupees to provide relief to the quake-affected people.

> Providing relief is one side of the coin, but it is better to be prepared well for any natural calamities or health hazards.

As the victims seem to need immediate help, bureaucratic 'red tape-ism' must be broken while helping these helpless victims. Now that the Finance Ministry has released funds, it is up to the local level authorities to see that the funds are properly utilised and the actual victims receive the government's gesture in recognising their plight.

One must also not forget the efforts of many youths, who have acted promptly to help the victims. This writer met a youngster by the name of Kalyani, who not only went to the worst affected village of Nalgud in Jajarkot district, but stayed there to oversee the distribution of food and warm clothing to the victims. She told this writer that the 'one door' policy of the government hindered in some way the distribution of relief packages she had taken to the village. 'We know the good intentions of the government but such regulations must be done away with when individuals want to help these people' she said. Kalyani works for a local NGO, which also helped her by providing expenses for her travel and also a token amount of funds to provide food to the victims.

This is an admirable 'proactive' effort of an individual when many other youths are seeking to go abroad, and the government must also seek to encourage such youths to stay back in the country and work for the development of the nation in whatever way they can.

Meanwhile, the government must also accept the fact that Nepal is not only prone to earthquakes, which is not predictable, but also other natural calamities like floods and landslides which take place during the rainy seasons and which can be avoided with proper regulations and preventive measures.

Permanent mechanism

We need a permanent mechanism for disaster management. For now we must be satisfied with temporary relief, but we need a sense of security not only for natural calamities, but also health hazards like COVID-19, dengue and such spreading diseases which have troubled many nations of the world, especially the least developed ones.

The government must recognise the expertise of other more developed nations with strong economies and also seek their cooperation, so that we can also deal more efficiently with incidents of disaster. For example look at how quickly the Chinese government reacted when a deadly quake hit two of its provinces a few days back. It is the same with India which also instantly went into action when a deadly new virus was detected in one of its states.

Providing relief is one side of the coin, but it is better to be prepared well for any natural calamities or health hazards. But for now, helping the 'helpless' in Jajarkot and West Rukum is enough.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

Patriotism Must For Nation-building

Prof. Bhupa P. Dhamala



Many nations have been built by their citizens with hard labour. Many nations have risen in their name and fame. Many others have also fallen due to their own faults. The rise and fall of a nation depends not just on particular circumstances that prevail at the time but it also depends on the attitudes and behaviours of the people of that nation. More specifically, leaders of the nation are responsible for the rise and fall of that nation.

For a nation to build on a solid foundation, the citizens of that nation have to work very hard. They have to perform Herculean tasks to build the nation. The term "Herculean tasks" refers to an ancient Greek myth where Hercules was a hero who once had made some mistake for which he was punished. According to the myth, Apollo understood that Hercules' alleged crime had not been his fault but he was the victim of Hera's vengeful actions. Yet, he insisted that the young man could make amends to live a heroic life if he performed hard work. So, he ordered Hercules to perform twelve hard labours for the Mycenaen king Eurystheus. Apollo assured that once Hercules completed all those hard labours, he would be absolved of his guilt and achieve immortality like that of gods.

Hercules was an individual citizen of the ancient Greek city-state where citizens were largely guided by the sense of virtue and vice. Zeus was the God of Mount Olympus who would decide who was guilty and who was innocent. Unlike in the ancient city-state, the citizens of a modern nation are not punished or rewarded. In the age of democracy, there is no such thing as eternal monarchy, let alone immortal God to scrutinise human actions. The citizens of a modern democratic nation do not make mistakes in the above-mentioned mythical sense. Nor should they be absolved of their mistakes in that sense. But still, they have to be guided by the ethical sense in the modern sense – the sense that they should work hard not only for themselves but equally for the nation as a whole.

Major impediments

The first and foremost impediment to the act of nation-building is the unpatriotic attitude of the leading class. They say good things but act otherwise. This paradox is one of the major impediments for the process of nation-building. This has been a public discourse which we can hear everywhere we go – workplace, marketplace, public institutions, social media, etc. To express anxiety over the issue is important but expression alone is not enough. We should rather act as we say in the real sense of the term. Saying must be doing, words must be deeds if we want really to build a nation. We should be committed to work days and nights for high or low wages or even no wages at all. The citizens of a nation have to be encouraged by the leaders becoming a good example themselves rather than simply making speech in the public places. Mere rhetoric does not work today.

But the things that ought to happen are not happening these days. Who is to blame for this unfortunate situation? A particular political leader or a high-level bureaucrat involved in policy formulation and its enactment is not to blame individually. Today's public discourse is that Nepal is not a good place to live in. In actions too, many of us are making our country simply a working station for making money for individual and family living. We do not offer even the lowest percentage of free-of-cost labour for the country and its people. We blame others for not doing what we expect them to do. But we seem to forget that others also expect us to do for them. We demand that our rights be fulfilled without being aware of our responsibility. We seem to have forgotten that rights and responsibilities should go together.

> Unless we develop the sense of togetherness in mind and heart, unless we cultivate patriotic attitude, our nation cannot be built.

The byproduct of the above mentioned attitude and behaviour is the fleeing of intelligent youths in foreign nations never to return. If this trend continues for a few years, mediocrity prevails in the country. This can become next major impediment to nation-building in the near future. It may be our stupidity not to sense the danger of meritorious intellectual depletion in the country. This blatant truth cannot be denied on any pretext. Although this is a matter of national concern and fiercely argumentative debate, we have not taken it seriously to rectify the worsening situation. This indifference to the serious issue of this scale is more than dangerous.

Imagined Community

The only way to help improve the situation is to understand the meaning of nation-building in the real sense of the term. If the nation is really built, the youths surely stop fleeing to foreign countries deserting their birthplace. One might deny the statement that youths are flying because they are unpatriotic. But the incidents prove otherwise. If they had had deserving employment opportunities with sound wages and due respect for their labour, they would have certainly stayed at home to make it a paradise.

There are different views about what is involved in nation building. Benedict Anderson (1983) produced a book titled "Imagined Communities" to talk about the significance of nationalism. Anderson does not believe in the notion of a nation as simply a geographical territory. For him, a nation is a "socially-constructed community, imagined by the people who perceive themselves as part of a group". In this sense, a nation is the composite whole of various communities who have common culture and common understanding about the territory they are living in. Our urgent need is to understand this notion and adapt it to fit our situation. Unless we develop the sense of togetherness in mind and heart, unless we cultivate patriotic attitude, our nation cannot be built. So, let us join our hands forgetting the differences of all kinds – political, religious, ethnic, and lingual.

(The author is the chairman of Molung Foundation. bhupadhamala@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 22, 1973

Flower Show

Kathmandu, Dec 21: The fourth flower show is to be held this month under the auspices of Bhrikuti Mandap office, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Resume Midday Meal Programme



This is in reference to a news report titled *"Chepang children in trouble with suspension of midday meal programme"* published in the digital edition of your prestigious daily Thursday.

According to the news report, children belonging to the Chepang community have stopped coming to school as the midday meal programme has been suspended. So, even those children who do attend the school are left hungry. Apparently, one and a half months has passed since the programme was discontinued in Jinglau, Chitwan.

It is said that neither the school management nor the local authorities are made aware of this suspension. However, the school mentions that the amount for the programme has been deposited in the school and it would disburse after observing the attendance.

Midday meal programme is very crucial in the rural parts of Nepal. A lack of money has prevented parents from sending their children to school. And this kind of initiative encourages children to attend school as they receive meals. The programme not only encourages education but also helps assist children belonging to poor families suffering from hunger.

The local authorities should strictly monitor whether the schools are properly mobilising the government-granted resources for the school children. And in the case where it is not, proper actions should be taken for the same.

Shruti Karki
Gatthaghar, Bhaktapur

TAILPIECE

Tom, Dick and Harry went to a party. After the party they returned to the hotel. The hotel was 600 stories high.

Unfortunately for them, the elevator was not working. They made a plan for the first 200 stories, Tom will crack jokes.

The second 200 stories Dick will tell a happy story and lastly Harry will tell a sad story.

They then started up the steps

After 2 hours it was Harry's turn.

He turned to the other two and said "Ok guys, here's my sad story. I forgot the keys downstairs.

+++++

Police officer pulled this guy over for speeding and told him that his eyes were bloodshot, and asked him if he'd been drinking. The guy said "Your eyes are glazed, have you been eating donuts?"

Israel uncovers major Hamas command centre in Gaza City



Photo: AP

Smoke rises following an Israeli bombardment on Rafah, southern Gaza Strip, Wednesday, Dec. 20, 2023.

AP
Jerusalem, Dec. 21

The Israeli military on Wednesday said it had uncovered a major Hamas command center in the heart of Gaza City, inflicting what it described as a serious blow to the Islamic militant group as pressure grows on Israel to scale back its devastating military offensive in the coastal enclave.

The army said it had exposed the center of a vast underground network used by Hamas to move weapons, militants and supplies throughout the Gaza Strip. Israel has said destroying the tunnels is a major objective of the offensive.

The announcement came as Hamas' top leader arrived in Egypt for talks aimed at brokering a temporary cease-fire and a new deal for Hamas to swap Israeli hostages for Palestinians imprisoned by Israel.

Israeli leaders have vowed to press ahead with the two-month-old offensive, launched in response to a bloody cross-border attack by Hamas in October that killed some 1,200 people and saw 240 others taken hostage.

The offensive has devastated much of northern Gaza, killed nearly 20,000 Palestinians, and driven some 1.9 million people — nearly 85% of the population — from their homes. The widespread destruction and heavy civilian death toll has drawn increasing international calls for a cease-fire.

Hamas militants have put up stiff resistance lately against Israeli ground troops, and its forces appear to remain largely intact in southern Gaza. It also continues to fire rockets into Israel every day.

The United States, Israel's closest ally, has continued to support Israel's right to defend itself while also urging greater effort to protect Gaza's civilians.

But in some of the toughest American language yet, Secretary of State Antony Blinken on Wednesday called on Israel to scale back its operation.

"It's clear that the conflict will move and needs to move to a lower intensity phase," Blinken said. He said the U.S. wants to see "more targeted operations" with smaller levels of forces focused on specific targets, such as Hamas' leaders and the group's tunnel network.

"As that happens, I think you'll see as well, the harm done to civilians also decrease significantly," he said.

His comments were more pointed than statements by Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin, who in a visit to Israel this week said the U.S. would not dictate any timeframes to its ally.

The Israeli military escorted Israeli reporters into Palestine Square in the heart of Gaza City to show off what it described as the center of Hamas' tunnel network.

China quake survivors recover in hospitals



Photo: AFP

Doctors attended to quake survivors with mild injuries at the Jishishan County People's Hospital.

AFP
China, Dec. 21

Chinese earthquake survivors recovered in hospital as rescue teams rushed to deliver supplies on Thursday, the third day since the country's deadliest quake in years killed 135 people.

The toll rose from the previous day's 134, state news agency Xinhua said, as rescuers continued to search for victims buried as the soil liquified in northwestern Qinghai Province.

Almost 1,000 were injured across Qinghai and neighbouring Gansu province after the strong, shallow tremor hit the region on Monday night.

At the Jishishan County People's Hospital in Gansu, near the epicentre of the quake, doctors attended to survivors with mild injuries on Thursday, administering intravenous drips and examining X-rays in buildings visibly damaged by the tremor.

"I really want to go home," one patient, a middle-aged woman waiting to receive surgery on her injured leg, told AFP. "But my place has been destroyed, so I wonder where I can go," she said.

"People are still worried about the aftershocks, they can't sleep well because there is no safe place", a Jishishan county official told AFP.

The US Geological Survey said Monday night's magnitude-5.9 quake struck at 11:59 pm local time (1559 GMT) with an epicentre about 100 kilometres from Gansu's provincial capital, Lanzhou.

Dozens of smaller aftershocks followed and officials warned that tremors with a magnitude of more than 5.0 were possible in the next few days.

Rescuers from across the country appeared to have reached more survivors in rural Gansu overnight, with AFP reporters seeing that large numbers of government-issued blue tents had been put up in Jishishan to replace improvised shelters built by residents immediately after the quake.

In Qinghai province, 12 people remain missing after a "sand boil" disaster on Tuesday buried people alive and in Zhongchuan Township, according to Xinhua.

'China-Philippines relations facing serious difficulties'

AFP
Philippines, Dec. 21

Videos released by the Philippine Coast Guard showed Chinese ships blasting water cannon at Philippine boats this month and there was also a collision between vessels from the two countries during tense clashes at flashpoint reefs.

Wang Yi, China's top diplomat, said on a call with Philippine Foreign Minister Enrique Manalo on Wednesday the two countries were "facing serious difficulties", blaming Manila for changing its policies, according to a readout.

"Wang Yi said China-Philippines relations are currently facing serious difficulties," it said late on Wednesday.

"The root cause is that the Philippines has changed its longstanding policy stance, reneged on its own commitments, continued to provoke and stir trouble at sea, and undermined China's legal rights."

"China-Philippines relations are at a crossroads. Faced with the choice of where to go, the Philippines must act with caution," the readout said.

China claims almost the entire South China Sea and has ignored an international tribunal ruling that its assertions have no legal basis. It deploys boats to patrol the busy waterway and has built artificial islands that it has militarised to reinforce its claims.

Manalo described his call with Wang as "frank and candid", according to a readout released by the Philippines foreign ministry on Thursday.



Photo: AFP

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi at the State Department in Washington, US, October 27, 2023.

"We had a frank and candid exchange and ended our call with a clearer understanding of our respective positions on a number of issues," the readout quoted Manalo as saying.

"We both noted the importance of dialogue in addressing these issues."

The Philippines summoned China's envoy on December 11 and flagged the possibility of expelling him following the latest clashes.

The videos released by the Philippines were of incidents during two separate resupply missions to fishermen at Scarborough Shoal and a tiny garrison at Second Thomas Shoal the previous weekend.

There was also a collision between Philippine and Chinese boats at Second Thomas Shoal, where a handful of Filipino troops are stationed on a grounded warship, with both countries trading blame. Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos met Chinese leader Xi Jinping last month on the sidelines of an Asia-Pacific summit in San Francisco, where the pair discussed the maritime territorial disputes.

Poland's cabinet sacks state media bosses

AFP
Poland, Dec. 21

The shakeup comes a week after Prime Minister Donald Tusk took power and after eight years of rule by the right-wing Law and Justice (PiS) party.

PiS politicians denounced the media reshuffle as "illegal", while their ally, the country's president, called on the government to "respect Poland's legal order". State-owned media under the PiS were regularly accused of biased reporting, transmitting government propaganda and launching verbal attacks on the opposition.

The culture ministry said in a statement the chairmen and boards of the state-owned television, radio, and news agency had been removed in a bid to restore the "impartiality" of public media.

Shortly after the announcement, state news channel TVP's regular broadcast was suspended, with only the television logo visible on TV screens.

On Tuesday, the new ruling bloc had adopted a resolution calling for the restoration of the "impartiality and reliability of the public media".

But PiS lawmakers largely boycotted the parliamentary vote, staging a sit-in in the state television buildings that continued through the night into Wednesday.

And on Wednesday, President Andrzej Duda weighed in.

"In connection with the culture ministry's actions today regarding public media, I call on Prime Minister Donald Tusk and the cabinet to respect Poland's legal order," he wrote on X.

Attached, was a letter to Tusk in which he said that "a parliament resolution does not have the force of law".

Tusk immediately tweeted back, saying: "as I already informed you, today's actions are – in accordance with your intention – aimed at restoring legal order and common decency in public life. "You can count on our iron determination on this matter," he added.

Following the changes in state media management, PiS chairman Jaroslaw Kaczynski was seen entering the state television building.

Kaczynski is the party's most prominent politician and for eight years was widely regarded as Poland's de facto leader.

"There is no democracy without media pluralism or strong anti-government media, and in Poland these are the public media," he told reporters on Tuesday evening.

Kaczynski said PiS politicians could continue the protest on rotating shifts.

Former prime minister Mateusz Morawiecki, also present in the building, said "a forcible intrusion" of the new management was taking place in state-owned television.

"What we are seeing is the first step towards a dictatorship," Morawiecki told reporters.

PRISM

Engagement ring lost returned by stranger

Columbus: A woman who left her engagement ring in a rest stop bathroom was reunited with the precious item a little more than a day later thanks to a stranger and a Facebook post.

Bailey Davis said she was on her way to work at a car auction in Columbus, Ohio, when she stopped at a Gallia County rest stop a little after noon.

Davis said she already was in the Columbus area when she realized she had left her ring at the rest stop and turned around. But when she arrived back where she had left the ring, it was gone.

Coty Warren had visited the rest stop a short time after Davis, and used the single family bathroom because the men's room was being cleaned.

Book checked out in 1934 returned now

Massachusetts : A book checked out for two weeks from a Massachusetts library was returned 90 years later after turning up in Washington, D.C.

The Watertown Free Public Library said in a Facebook post that the book, Hill Towns of Italy by Egerton R. Williams Jr., was checked out Jan. 30, 1934, and was supposed to have been returned 14 days later.

The book's journey back to the library turned out to be far longer, however, as it only made its way back to the facility this week after a "far-flung patron" found it in Washington and dropped it off at the library during a trip to Boston.

(AP)

'AI image-generators being trained on explicit photos of children'

AP
New York, Dec. 21

Hidden inside the foundation of popular artificial intelligence image-generators are thousands of images of child sexual abuse, according to a new report that urges companies to take action to address a harmful flaw in the technology they built.

Those same images have made it easier for AI systems to produce realistic and explicit imagery of fake children as well as transform social media photos of fully clothed real teens into nudes, much to the alarm of schools and law enforcement around the world.

Until recently, anti-abuse researchers thought the only way that some unchecked AI tools produced abusive imagery of children was by essentially combining what they've learned from two separate buckets of online images — adult pornography and benign photos of kids.

But the Stanford Internet Observatory found more than 3,200 images of suspected child sexual abuse in the giant AI database LAION, an index of online images and captions that's been used to train leading AI image-makers such as Stable Diffusion. The watchdog group based at Stanford University worked with the Canadian Centre for Child Protection and other anti-abuse charities to identify the illegal material and report the original photo links to law enforcement. It said roughly 1,000 of the images it found were externally validated.



Photo: AP

Students walk on the Stanford University campus on March 14, 2019, in Stanford, Calif.

The response was immediate. On the eve of the Wednesday release of the Stanford Internet Observatory's report, LAION told The Associated Press it was temporarily removing its datasets.

LAION, which stands for the nonprofit Large-scale Artificial Intelligence Open Network, said in a statement that it "has a zero tolerance policy for illegal content and in an abundance of caution, we have taken down the LAION datasets to ensure they are safe before republishing them."

While the images account for just a fraction of LAION's index of some 5.8 billion images, the Stanford group says it is likely influencing the ability of AI tools to generate harmful outputs and reinforcing the prior abuse of real victims who appear multiple times.

It's not an easy problem to fix, and traces back to many generative AI projects being "effectively rushed to market" and made widely accessible because the field is so competitive, said Stanford Internet Observatory's chief technologist David Thiel, who authored the report.

"Taking an entire internet-wide scrape and making that dataset to train models is something that should have been confined to a research operation, if anything, and is not something that should have been open-sourced without a lot more rigorous attention," Thiel said in an interview.

A prominent LAION user that helped shape the dataset's development is London-based startup Stability AI, maker of the Stable Diffusion text-to-image models. New versions of Stable Diffusion have made it much harder to create harmful content, but an older version introduced last year — which Stability AI says it didn't release — is still baked into other applications and tools and remains "the most popular model for generating explicit imagery," according to the Stanford report.

"We can't take that back. That model is in the hands of many people on their local machines," said Lloyd Richardson, director of information technology at the Canadian Centre for Child Protection, which runs Canada's hotline for reporting online sexual exploitation.

Stability AI on Wednesday said it only hosts filtered versions of Stable Diffusion and that "since taking over the exclusive development of Stable Diffusion, Stability AI has taken proactive steps to mitigate the risk of misuse."

TODAY IN HISTORY

1790 – The Turkish fortress of Izmail is stormed and captured by Alexander Suvorov and his Russian armies.
1807 – The Embargo Act, forbidding trade with all foreign countries, is passed by the U.S. Congress at the urging of President Thomas Jefferson.
1945 – U.S. President Harry S. Truman issues an executive order giving World War II refugees precedence in visa applications under U.S. immigration quotas.[24]
1987 – In Zimbabwe, the political parties ZANU and ZAPU reach an agreement that ends the violence in the Matabeleland region known as the Gukurahundi.[31]
2017 – United Nations Security Council Resolution 2397 against North Korea is unanimously approved.
2018 – A tsunami caused by an eruption of Anak Krakatau in Indonesia kills at least 430 people and injures almost a thousand more.

MAOIST CENTRE TO HOLD STATUTE MEET IN FEBRUARY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The ruling CPN (Maoist Centre) has decided to hold its statute conference in mid-February next year.

A meeting of the party office bearers held on Thursday decided this.

After the meeting, party vice-president and spokesperson Agni Prasad Sapkota informed that the meeting also formed a 7-member committee to prepare a statute draft.

Party vice-president Pumpha Bhusal, general secretary Dev Gurung, deputy general secretaries Girirajmani Pokharel, Barsaman Pun and Janardan Sharma, secretaries Ganesh Sah and secretary Ram Karki are in the committee.

In the meeting, the party's ongoing Janatasanga Maobadi, Bisesh Rupantaran Aviayan (People with Maoist, Special Transformation Campaign) was also analysed and the meeting concluded the campaign has made the party live, movable and rebuilt relationship between party workers and people.

Sapkota said the campaign was effective. The party has scheduled to end the campaign on January 1 next year by mobilising people in all municipalities. Sapkota said no discussion was held in the meeting about the resignation tendered by Haribol Gajurel, political advisor of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda.

NAC TO AUCTION CHINESE AIRCRAFT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) has put up five of its old planes for auction.

Issuing a public notice on Thursday, the Corporation announced the auction of two MA-60 and three Y-12 E aircraft on an "As Is Where Is Basis." These planes have remained grounded for the last three years.

Under the auction, the Corporation has invited bids from all interested companies and individuals. As per the notice, the sealed bid documents must reach NAC's Corporate Department by 1 pm on February 4, 2024. Those who place the highest bids will receive the aircraft.

The planes are part of a fleet of six crafts the Corporation had brought from China in the past decade. Two of the planes had been provided has grants while four had been purchased.

Of the six craft, one crashed in Nepalgunj 2020 while the remaining five have now been put up for sale.

CIAA FILES CASE AGAINST GUPTA AT SUPREME COURT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) appealed a case against defendant Madan Prasad Gupta and his family members at the Supreme Court on Thursday after being dissatisfied with the verdict of the Special Court on September 7.

According to the CIAA, Gupta had illegally acquired Rs. 148.18 million while serving as a civil servant from July 11, 1990, to Fiscal Year 2018/019. While preparing the Cash Flow Chart of Gupta, his total income was Rs. 45,472,246 and his total expenditure was Rs. 193,661,169 during the period.

The CIAA demanded the confiscation of movable and non-movable properties without a source of Gupta and his family members worth Rs. 148.18 million in accordance with the former Prevention of Corruption Act-1960 and the Prevention of Corruption Act-2002.



PHOTO: RSS

A cannon has been put on display in Sindhuligadhi of Sindhuli district. The ancient artillery was returned to the place after 42 years.

Next 5-year plan will be pragmatic, says NPC

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The National Planning Commission (NPC) has said that the next five-year plan will be made more pragmatic to realise the concept of 'building a prosperous country with proper planning and decision'.

Speaking at a press conference organised at the NPC on Thursday to inform about the progress regarding the formulation of the upcoming 16th National Plan (Fiscal Year 2081/82 to FY 2085/86), Vice-Chairman of the NPC, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha claimed to make the next five-year plan result-oriented and reality-based, and advance the all-round development of the country in a planned manner.

Stating that the COVID-19 pandemic and the Russia-Ukraine war have affected the achievement of the goals of the 15th five-year plan, he said the weaknesses in planning and executions would be addressed by the upcoming 16th plan.

According to him, the NPC is continuing various consultations and studies to prepare a five-year plan which will be continued till mid-February 2024.

"As the country will be upgraded to a developing nation from the Least developed country within the period of the 16th plan, the NPC is making preparations to address the challenges of the upgrading. We need to make the transition to the developing country a smooth one, and for it we have been putting in our efforts," said Dr. Shrestha.

He also claimed that the new plan will include a strategy to prevent youth migration by connecting and promoting employment and production in the country. "We will get a great opportunity to bring in foreign investment when we are upgraded to the status of a developing country. We are developing a strategy to embrace such opportunities and face the challenges," he said.

The NPC informed that it has created a procedure to change the traditional thinking and methods seen in the budgeting process. A member of the NPC, Dr. Ram Kumar Phuyal, said that an action plan has been prepared to accept the amendments and modifications of the sovereign parliament in the government's policies programmes and budget.

According to him, preparations are being made to submit the action plan to the Cabinet.

The committee formed under the coordination of Dr. Phuyal has already prepared a report. It has recommended that the government's policies and programmes, principles and priorities of the budget and economic surveys should be submitted to the parliament earlier than the current time arrangement.

Two accused held after seven years of Balkhu murder case

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Two men, who were absconding after killing a woman in Balkhu, Kathmandu, have been arrested seven years after the murder incident. Jagat Bishwakarma, a resident of Shitaganga Municipality-14, Arghakhanchi, was arrested from the Tribhuvan International Airport after police got the tip-off that he was coming to Nepal from abroad.

Shiva Ram Adhikari, 46, of Tripurasundari Rural Municipality-3 in Dhading district, believed to be the mastermind behind the murder, who was already serving jail sentence in other cases, was arrested again.

Organising a press conference on Thursday, the Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office made the two public. Bishwakarma together with Shiva Ram had killed Narayani Timilsina alias Apsara of Handikhola Ward No. 6 of Makwanpur at Bokshidaha hill behind Bhubaneswari Temple in Balkhu, Kathmandu Metropolitan City-14 on November 16, 2017.

According to the Superintendent of Police (SP) and Information Officer for the Office Rabindra Regmi, Apsara and Shiva Ram knew each other before the incident. Shiva Ram had lured the woman saying that he knew one ex-army and would marry her. When the woman was convinced by the idea of Shiva Ram, he then advised the woman to come for the marriage in the temple carrying some cash and wearing jewellery.

The three persons met at the Machhapokhari area of Balaju, stayed at a restaurant eating something for 2-3 hours, before boarding a public bus, said police. "They enjoyed dinner at Kusunti in Lalitpur and returned to the Balkhu area to sleep," said police.

After sleeping together with Apsara for two hours, Shiva Ram sent Jagat to the hill near the temple to observe whether someone was coming there.

Then Shiva Ram hit Apsara on her head with a stone several times. According to the police, Jagat also hit Apsara with stones twice.

After the murder, they took out the gold earrings worn by Apsara and the cash of Rs. 600 to 700 from her bag and then went to Gongabu and stayed stay at Kopila Guest House. The police managed to arrest Jagat from the Tribhuvan International Airport at 9:00 pm on Wednesday after getting a tip-off that the fugitive was coming to Nepal.

It was revealed that Shiva Ram was imprisoned for three years in a theft case at the Central Jail from November 13, 2022. According to the police, Shiva Ram had changed his name to Arjun Adhikari and was still in the Central Jail.

For further investigation, the case has been forwarded to the Kalimati Police Office.

MISSTEPS OVER YEARS ALLOWED A DETROIT SERIAL KILLER TO ROAM FREE

AP
Detroit, | Dec.21

The serial killer lured women one by one into vacant homes to be murdered, posing their nude or partially clothed corpses amid cheap booze pints, crumbling sheetrock and hypodermic needles.

The slayings set Detroit on edge, prompting authorities to dispatch crews on overtime to scour the city's decrepit stock of abandoned properties for more bodies. When the killer was charged in 2019, the police chief at the time told reporters that his department had been "very diligent, relentless" in solving the crimes.

But now, a year after DeAngelo Martin was sent to prison for committing four murders and two rapes, it's clear that police were hardly diligent or relentless. Over 15 years, Detroit police failed to follow up on leads or take investigative steps that may have averted the eventual killing spree, despite having received repeated warnings that Martin was a violent predator, an Associated Press investigation has found.

"It's astonishing," said Jim Trainum, a retired Washington, D.C., homicide detective who specializes in reviewing police investigations for possible wrongful convictions. "All the police had to do was one little thing, one little thing here or there, and they would have put a stop to this whole process and these women would still be alive. Just one thing."

'Planned, smart cities should be developed'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that smart cities should be built by emphasising the development of planned cities.

The Prime Minister said this while addressing a joint meeting between the Ministry of Urban Development and the Ministry of Forests and Environment held at Singha Durbar on Thursday afternoon.

He said, "An organised model city should be built within the Kathmandu Valley. During my second tenure, the concept of Smart City was advanced with this vision."

"We envisioned the construction of a smart city in each province. We aim to develop a planned city in each province and term them as Smart Cities. This represents a strategic, long-term plan, requiring careful consideration for its effective implementation," he stated.

"It is our responsibility to build administrative buildings for all local levels. When talking about urbanisation, we must also prioritise enhancing urban beauty," the Prime Minister said.

Stating that he had been consistently advocating for development aligned with the geographical situation, he said "Our progress should establish connectivity between the east-west and north-south regions. This comprehensive perspective should guide our approach."

"The inception of the Madhya Pahadi Lokmarga occurred during my first tenure as Prime Minister. We also advanced the construction of the postal highway. The North-South Corridor represents our vision for development. The development model should align with the country's circumstances, geographical structure, and evolving economic characteristics," the Prime Minister.

During the meeting, Minister for Urban Development Sita Gurung said there was the challenge of balancing between the multitude of projects and the constraints posed by budget limitations.

She said that the endeavour to build the planned cities should be incorporated in the national pride project.

Stating that the ministry has made good progress towards the construction of private housing within a year, she said that the ministry would focus on rebuilding private houses devastated by the earthquake.

Likewise, Minister for Forest and Environment Birendra Mahato pointed out that the prolonged legal procedures for tree cutting have adversely affected the progress of development projects.

The customs policy regarding timber export lacks scientific basis, he said adding, "The ministry is dedicated to finding a viable solution to this issue."

Chief Secretary of the government, Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, expressed concern that the development policy would become imbalanced if the Ministry of Forest solely focuses on nature conservation while the Ministry of Development exclusively emphasizes development without considering environmental conservation.

Aryal highlighted that climate change significantly impacts various facets of physical development and human life.

He emphasized the importance of conducting an integrated analysis to understand the multifaceted effects of climate change across different areas.

During the discussion, the Secretary of the Ministry of Urban Development, Sarju Vaidya, mentioned that steps were initiated to ensure the efficient utilisation of the foreign aid budget.

Vaidya highlighted the necessity for adequate coordination between project levels and budget management and stressed the need for increasing manpower considering the workload demands. Vaidya said that the ministry is prepared to efficiently reconstruct the houses damaged by the devastating earthquakes in Rukum West and Jajarkot.

Highlighting the importance of identifying potential earthquake-prone areas and formulating policies accordingly, Vaidya mentioned that groundwork has completed works to establish seven smart cities across the seven provinces.

Similarly, the Secretary of the Ministry of Forest and Environment, Deepak Kharal, highlighted the ministry's stance in addressing issues such as prolonged duration and manpower requirements for forest area utilisation and tree cutting.

Secretary Kharal recalled Nepal's leadership role in COP-28 and mentioned plans to take initiatives in climate finance earmarked for Nepal.

Additionally, preparations are underway to host an international mountain summit, he added.

Likewise, Secretary of the Office of Prime Minister, Eak Narayan Aryal, expressed concerns about Nepal's indigenous wood decaying while a significant quantity of wood was being imported from overseas.

Another secretary, Ganesh Panda, suggested adopting a flexible policy for utilizing Nepal's wood domestically.

Summarising the meeting, the Prime Minister said, "Next year, we aim to progress with innovative thinking, planning, and a revised working approach. I am contemplating changing myself accordingly."

"I urge all of you to consider adopting new working styles to deliver qualitative results for the betterment of the country," he added.

EC fixes seven polling stations, 14 polling centres for NA poll

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The Election Commission has fixed the number of polling stations and voting centres for the January 25 National Assembly (NA) elections in all seven provinces.

The Election Commission (EC) has designated seven polling stations and 14 polling centres for the National Assembly elections, with one polling station in each province and two polling centres in each polling station.

Secretary and Spokesperson for the Commission Shaligram Sharma Paudel informed that the polling station for Koshi Province has been set in Koshi Provincial Election Office Biratnagar, Morang.

Similarly, for the Madhes Province, the polling station has been set in Mahendra Narayan Nidhi Mithila Culture Centre, Janakpurdham, Dhanusha, he added.

Likewise, the polling station has been set in Shree Bhutandevi Higher Secondary Technical College, Block 'F' Technical Building, Hetauda, Makwanpur for the Bagmati Province and at Provincial Election Office, Pokhara, Kaski for Gandaki Province.

In the same manner, the polling station has been set at the Staff meeting Centre Building in Ghorahi, Dang for Lumbini Province, at the Provincial Election Office, Surkhet, for Karnali Province and at the Provincial Assembly Building, Dhangadhi, for Sudurpaschim Province.

According to Paudel, separate polling stations will be arranged for members of the provincial assembly and local-level representatives to cast their votes at the designated polling stations.

The details of the polling station have been published on the EC's official website, he added. The voting is scheduled to take place at the designated polling stations between 9am and 3 pm.

The EC is scheduled to hold the election to the vacant posts of the members of the National Assembly, the upper house of the Federal Parliament on January 25.

Programme organised to mark 100 years of Nepal-UK Friendship Treaty

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

A commemorative programme was organised by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) of Nepal to mark the 100 years of Nepal-United Kingdom Friendship Treaty of 1923 at Singha Durbar, State Hall on Thursday.

The Friendship Treaty was signed on 21 December 1923 at the Singha Durbar State Hall one hundred years ago.

On the occasion, Minister for Foreign Affairs, Narayan Prakash Saud, delivered his remarks highlighting various aspects of age-old relations between Nepal and the United Kingdom, informed the MoFA in a statement.

Ambassador of the United Kingdom to Nepal, Rob Fenn, also spoke on the importance of the Treaty on Nepal-UK bilateral ties. The programme was attended by national security advisor, chief secretary, secretaries of different ministries, ambassadors, chiefs of security agencies, former foreign secretaries, former ambassadors and academia among others.

Scrap licenses held without initiating...

the country's economy is in a difficult situation.

On the occasion, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet said that in terms of hydropower production and consumption, it was necessary to import in winter and export in the rainy season.

He said that there was a problem in the consumption and exports of generated electricity due to the construction and management of the transmission lines.

The government should find a common solution to that, he added.

Similarly, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that necessary homework was done to increase the quality and reliability of government media.

She said that emphasis should be placed on manpower development in all state agencies according to the current state of affairs and that technology-friendly personnel administration is necessary.

Minister Sharma said that Ncell provided the decision of share purchase only on Wednesday and informed that it was being studied.

Likewise, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal directed the employees of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation to work seriously for the implementation of the agreement for the export of 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India.

He directed the secretaries to focus the ministries' attention on the planned action plan and list the works that can provide direct relief to the people.

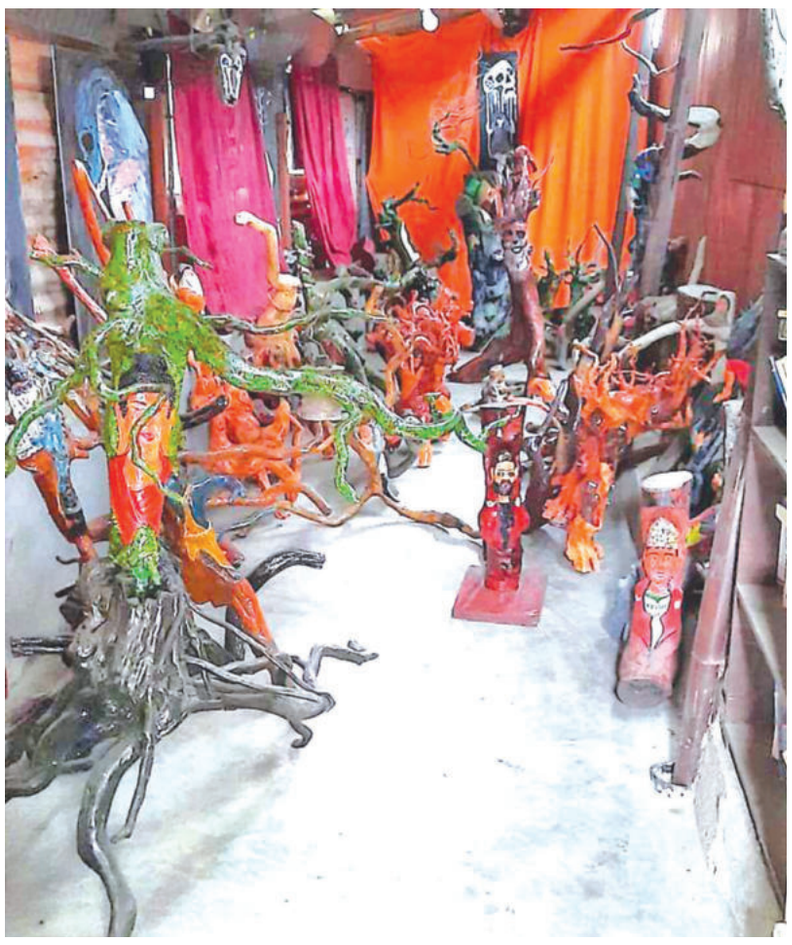
In the meeting, Energy Secretary Gopal Prasad Sigdel said that the process of land acquisition was complicated and the public procurement system takes time, which affects the construction of energy projects.

Secretary at the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology Krishna Bahadur Raut said that the ministry has given top priority to the policies related to communication.

In the discussion, Managing Director of Nepal Electricity Authority Kul Man Ghising said that it was necessary to focus on the collection of electricity tariff arrears.

Khadka gives life to dead tree roots through his artworks

BY RAMMANI DAHAL
Dolakha, Dec. 21



Sujan Khadka, a resident of Bhimeshwor Municipality in Dolakha district, has undergone a remarkable transformation as a tree root artist amidst the challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic.

Despite the chaos of COVID-19, Khadka seized the opportunity to showcase his artistic talents.

Skillfully carving intricate shapes into discarded tree roots, he has created 40 distinct figures.

Khadka's artworks delve into the relationship between humanity and nature, the inherent nature of Buddha, and the duality of demonic nature.

He has crafted tree root sculptures depicting Kathmandu Metropolitan City Mayor Balen Shah and Dharan Sub-Metropolitan City Mayor Harka Sampang, drawing inspiration from their election campaigns and activities.

Khadka intends to gift these sculptures to the Mayors Shah and Sampang.

Beyond tree roots, Khadka has extended his artistic vision to herbs, revealing shapes noticeable only to the keen eye of an artist.

His repertoire includes depictions of Mansarobar, the Kalpa tree, snakes, and more, showcasing the diversity of his creative expressions.

Khadka has established a Tree Root Handicraft Industry to transform his passion into a sustainable business.

Despite initially being a hobbyist painter, Khadka's creations have gained recognition and generated an income of Rs. 150,000 with the initial investment of Rs.500, 000.

Khadka aspires to cultivate and enhance tree root art into a sustainable business, anticipating the backing of the local government and favourable market conditions.

Additionally, he joyfully expressed that a company based in Kathmandu has shown keen interest in his unique tree root artworks. As a result, Khadka is delighted to see his artworks gaining recognition, bringing life to once-lifeless tree roots through his art.

Moreover, he holds a positive outlook on the market potential for his unique tree root artworks.

Khadka is doing his best to introduce this art form and explore its potential.

Emphasising the authenticity of his work, Khadka asserted that he does not engage in artificial modifications, rather, he lets the natural form of the tree roots guide his artistic expressions.

Bishwamber Lamichhane of Sindhuli too is engaged in similar work.

Reflecting on his journey, Khadka recounts spending 11 years in Kathmandu working in money transfer services after passing the School Leaving Certificate (SLC).

However, a desire for personal fulfilment led him to return to his roots, both figuratively and literally, as he embarked on this artistic venture.

Story writer Kusum comes up with Parswa Dhoon

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21



Parswa Dhoon (Background Sound), a collection of short stories in Nepali by Krishna Kusum, has hit the book stalls.

Published by Shikha Books Kathmandu, the book has 13 promising stories of miscellaneous flavours. The writer, who has been living in Texas, USA, has written almost all stories of Nepalis living in the USA and abroad.

Among the stories, New York Ma Bhetiyeko Desh (The Motherland Found in New York), Parijat, Blind Date, Euta Antya (The End) and Ladaku (Warrior) look marvelous.

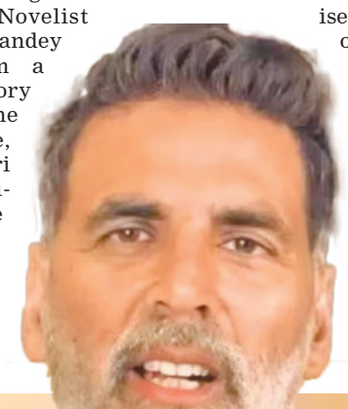
New York Ma Bhetiyeko Desh depicts the poignant story of Nepali old women who have true hearts but cannot fit in the USA. They face many obstacles and tragedies.

Parijat is the story of a Bhutanese refugee family of Dalit community who has to face untouchability among the Nepali community even in the USA. Blind Date depicts not only the destiny of Nepali students in the USA but also discloses the true face of the capitalist system. The narration and the style of the story is very playful.

Euta Antya is the story of the helpfulness of Bhutanese immigrants in the USA. The writer misses the helpfulness of an old man who has passed away recently. The writer's nostalgia may make the readers empathetic.

Ladaku tells the story of a warrior of Maoist Conflict (1996-2006). After the peace accord, the warrior faced many tough days and was compelled to go to the USA through an illegal process.

Other stories including Clone, Dutkar (Rejection), Anuttarit (The Unanswered), Maya Urf Paso (The Love or The Net), Gathaso (The Saga), Bharyang (The Ladder), Charlie, Apuro (The Incomplete) are also worth reading.



Veteran Novelist Nayan Raj Pandey found Kusum a proficient story teller. At the same time, critic Kumari Lama entitled him the spokesperson of Nepali immigrants in America, in the book release programme held recently in Kathmandu.

'Humane voice, sharp political and social consciousness and marginalised voice are the true assets of Kusum's short stories,' the publishing house has written in its blurb.

A civil engineer of the US government, Kusum had three books including Amrit Ko Pyala, a collection of ghazals, to his credit before this. He has edited many books including Paradesh Ka Katha, Hastakshar and Aagan Chhadepachhi.

Ryan Gosling reimagines his 'Barbie' power ballad 'I'm Just Ken' for Christmas

AP
New York, Dec. 21



She's Barbie. He's just Ken. And now, it's Christmas.

On Wednesday, Ryan Gosling — the Ken to Margot Robbie's "Barbie" in the film — released the "I'm Just Ken" EP alongside collaborators Mark Ronson and Andrew Wyatt. It features the original Grammy-nominated, '80s-style power ballad from the movie, also titled "I'm Just Ken," as well as three remixes: the stripped down "I'm Just Ken (In My Feelings Acoustic)," the dance floor ready "I'm Just Ken (Purple Disco Machine Remix)," and the festive "I'm Just Ken (Merry Kristmas Barbie)."

The later was released with an official music video, where Gosling, Wyatt and Ronson are seen working on the holiday remix of the song in a studio drenched in Christmas lights with an impressive live band, bantering with one another. At one point, a goofy Gosling puts on a pair of sunglasses to get into character, telling Ronson he's doing so because "the world can have Ken's voice but only Barbie can have his eyes."

The trio are joined by a full band as well by two cellists, four violinists and a glockenspiel. Gosling's vocals are run through reverb — adding to the triumphant and whimsical reimagining. "Merry Christmas, Barbie," he ends the song. "Wherever you are." In July, Ronson, who worked as the executive producer of the "Barbie" soundtrack and also scored it alongside Wyatt, told the Associated Press he typically only contributes music to songs for film — but in the case of "I'm Just Ken," couldn't shake a few lyrics that made the final cut, like its memorable chorus of "I'm just Ken, anywhere else I'd be a 10."

"I'm Just Ken" is up for best song written for visual media at the 2024 Grammy Awards as well as and the Golden Globe for best original song.

Akshay Kumar marks 16 years of 'Welcome'

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Dec. 21



"Bollywood actor Akshay Kumar marked the 16th anniversary of the hit movie 'Welcome' on Thursday and announced that Sanjay Dutt has joined the franchise for its upcoming third part. Kumar shared a photo from the sets of the movie titled 'Welcome To The Jungle,' directed by Ahmed Khan.

"What a lovely coincidence that we celebrate 16 years of 'Welcome' today while I am shooting for the franchise's third part, 'Welcome To The Jungle.' It's wonderful to welcome Sanju Baba in this one. What do you think?" the 56-year-old actor wrote. 'Welcome,' released on December 21, 2007, was a massive hit at the Indian box office. It featured Katrina Kaif, Anil Kapoor, Nana Patekar, Paresh Rawal, and the late Feroz Khan. The second movie, titled 'Welcome Back,' was released in 2015 and also became a box-office hit. Both films were directed by Anees Bazmee.

'Welcome To The Jungle' will showcase an ensemble cast, including Suniel Shetty, Raveena Tandon, Johnny Lever, Paresh Rawal, Lara Dutta, Rajpal Yadav, Arshad Warsi, Jacqueline Fernandez, Shreyas Talpade, Tusshar Kapoor, Disha Patani, Kiku Sharada, Krushna Abhishek, and singers Daler Mehndi and Mika Singh. The movie is scheduled to be released in theaters on December 20, 2024 next year.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Your best efforts may not suffice at the moment. The Sun and Mercury are conjoining in your 10th House of Professional Goals, but the problem is that Mercury is retrograde.

CANCER: Misunderstandings are the order of the day, but that doesn't mean you can't avoid them if you try. The Sun and Mercury are conjoining in your 7th House of Interactions with Others.

LIBRA: Your home can't always be a peaceful oasis. It might feel especially hectic today as the Sun and Mercury come together at the same degree in your domestic 4th house.

CAPRICORN: Feeling like yourself isn't presently straightforward. It could be especially difficult as the fiery Sun and muddy Mercury Retrograde come together in your own 1st House of Action.

TAURUS: The world is bigger than you realize -- and perhaps more daunting, too. You may be very aware of your boundaries as the Sun and Mercury align in your 9th House of Development.

LEO: Roadblocks are popping up everywhere you turn. This conflicting energy is thanks to the Sun and Mercury conjoining in your 6th House of Effective Routines.

SCORPIO: First impressions are probably incorrect at present. Socializing with pals is definitely encouraged as the Sun and Mercury conjoin in your 3rd House of Communications.

AQUARIUS: Your mind is racing into unseen places. There is a special conjunction between the Sun and Mercury in your subconscious sector, but because Mercury is retrograde.

GEMINI: Standing your ground isn't for the faint-hearted. Today could feel peculiarly extreme as the Sun and your ruler Mercury align at the same degree of your all-or-nothing 8th house.

VIRGO: vThe spotlight is not your friend at a time like this. Mercury Retrograde casts a shadow over the usually joyful conjunction of the energetic Sun and witty Mercury in your creative 5th house.

SAGITTARIUS: A deal that seems too good to be true is probably just that. You've got the urge to splurge as the Sun and Mercury conjoin in your 2nd House of Material Security.

PISCES: No one seems to be on the same page. The Sun and Mercury are conjoining in your 11th House of Social Networks, which would typically set up a wonderful day to circulate with friends.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Birgunj's playoff hopes soar after stunning title-defender Kathmandu

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The hope of entering the playoffs has turned slim for the defending champions Kathmandu Rayzrs FC (KRFC) after they suffered a 1-4 loss against Birgunj United FC (BUFC) at Nepal Super League on Thursday.

Despite getting into the lead with the first goal of the match, Kathmandu suffered a devastating loss against bottom-placed Birgunj. After the win, Birgunj climbed to the sixth position, one place below Kathmandu (9 points in 7 matches), with 8 points in 7 matches.

William Opoku scored the first hat trick of the season in the second win of Birgunj. Junior O. Nkengue scored the only goal for Kathmandu in the 20th minute.

A pass from Kuldip Karki from the right flank was received by Hishub Thapaliya. Thapaliya's possession was blocked by BUFC defenders but a poor clearance allowed Nkengue to send the ball to the back of the net.

After taking the lead KRFC was in complete control of the game while BUFC lost its momentum.

The scenario got more interesting when Hishub won a penalty for Kathmandu in the 37th minute, but the set piece by Shokhrukh Makhmudkhozhiev was stopped by Deep Karki, BUFC's goalie and captain.

The save prevented Kathmandu from extending its lead and motivated Birgunj players to fight for a win. While Kathmandu failed to score in the penalty, Birgunj did not.

A handball won a penalty for Birgunj in the 45+4 minutes of the first-half injury time. William Opoku scored the penalty and equalised for Birgunj before the first half concluded.

The second half was expected to be competitive, but it turned into a one-sided game as Birgunj added three more goals. Moreover, two of the final goals came in quick succession.



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN
Birgunj United FC's William Opoku Asiedu celebrates after scoring against defending champion Kathmandu Rayzrs FC during the Nepal Super League at Dashrath Stadium, Kathmandu, Thursday.

Birgunj extended its lead as soon as the second half started. In the 46th minute, Kathmandu's goalie Anjal Shrestha failed to stop a pass inside the six-yard box by Obed Owusu allowing Sunil Khadka to score.

The third goal came in the 56th minute as Opoku headed a corner beating Anjal. As Kathmandu was coping with a sudden two-goal lead of Birgunj, Opoku made it four for the team and completed his hat trick by chipping the ball above the keeper from outside the 18-yard box in the 57th minute.

Opoku, who scored the first hat trick of the season, was adjudged the player of the match.

After the three-goal lead by Birgunj, Bal Gopal Maharjan, coach of KRFC, was seen along the sidelines shouting to the players to make a comeback; however, Kathmandu could not.

While Birgunj has increased its hopes of reaching the playoffs with a game remaining, Kathmandu can also make it to the top four.

Birgunj is facing seventh-positioned FC Butwal Lumbini (7 points in 7 matches) in the first match and Kathmandu will be facing third-positioned Lalitpur City FC (10 points in 7 matches) in the second match on Saturday.

Pokhara Thunders and Dhangadhi FC will be looking for the top spot when they meet each other in the first match on Friday. Jhapa FC will be strengthening their top four positions with a win over bottom-placed Chitwan FC on Friday evening.

Meanwhile, the Disciplinary Committee of NSL has imposed a Marquee and Goalkeeper of Sporting Ilam FC one-match ban. "He has been found violating NSL Conduct standards during the match against Birgunj United FC on December 13. For his verbal and physical aggression towards officials, he will serve a one-match ban and has been imposed with a personal fine of Rs. 10, 000," the NSL statement read.

Likewise, Rabindra Silakar, Assistant coach of Lalitpur FC, has been banned from all NSL-related activities. NSL said Silakar has been found involved in physical and verbal aggression with racial discrimination towards the referee Surojit Das during the match of Sporting Ilam FC and Lalitpur City FC on December 19."

Silakar has also been fined Rs 20,000. He faced a red card during the match.

Bagmati, APF, Koshi, Lumbini start PM Cup Women's Cricket with wins



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Bagmati Province, Armed Police Force (APF), Lumbini Province and Koshi Province emerged victorious in the four opening matches of the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament that started on Thursday.

Bagmati defeated Madhesh Province by 28 runs and Lumbini notched up a four-wicket win over Gandaki Province at the TU Cricket Ground.

Likewise, APF trounced Sudurpashchim Province by nine wickets and Koshi eased past Karnali Province by 10 wickets in the Upper Mulpani Cricket Ground.

In the 20 overs, Bagmati gave a target of 118 to Madhesh in the loss of four wickets. Yashoda Bist and Ashmina Karmacharya remained not out at 47 (39) and 30 (31) respectively to help Bagmati post the target.

However, Madhesh was only able to score 89 in the loss of five wickets by the end of 20 overs. Puja Mahato was Madhes' highest scorer with 35 runs off 45 balls.

Title defender APF also started the campaign with a win. The second-wicket partnership of Jyoti Pandey, who scored 49 off 48 balls, and Indu Barma (31 runs off 44 balls) helped APF reach the victory target of 88. Sudurpashchim's batters could only score 87 in the loss of nine wickets.

On the other hand, Koshi got hold of the easiest win of the day. After restricting Karnali to a total of 33 for the loss of nine wickets in the match reduced to 16 overs at Mulpani, Openers Rubina Chhetry, 25 off 17 balls, and Kajal Shrestha, 5 off 3 balls, steered Koshi to the victory target in 3.1 overs.

Koshi's bowlers Apsara Begam took three wickets and gave 12 runs while Alisha Khadiya took two wickets and gave only three runs against Karnali.

In the fourth match of the day, Laxmi Chaudhary's knock of 42 runs from 44 balls helped Lumbini reach the target of 103 with three overs remaining.

Electing to bat first, Gandaki rode on a knock of 33 runs off 18 balls of Sooman Khatiwada to score 102/4 in 20 overs. Khatiwada and Anjali Bishwokarma (30 off 51) remained not out for Gandaki.

Bagmati, Karnali, Madhes and Lumbini will be playing against Koshi, Gandaki, APF and Sudurpashchim on Friday respectively.

Liverpool dominate West Ham to reach League Cup semis

AFP
Liverpool, Dec. 21

Liverpool destroyed West Ham 5-1 on Wednesday to set up a League Cup semi-final against Fulham, easing the frustration of their weekend Premier League stalemate against Manchester United.

Curtis Jones scored twice and Dominik Szoboszlai, Cody Gakpo and Mohamed Salah were also on the scoresheet for Jurgen Klopp's dominant team, who were trophyless last season.

No team have won more League Cups than Liverpool, who lifted the trophy for the ninth time in the 2021/22 season. Manager Jurgen Klopp said he was delighted with his team's "joyful football" as they once again clicked in front of goal against West Ham.

"We were brave in our positioning, our second ball game was exceptional," he said.

"It was a really, really good performance from start to finish.

"It is really tough for all of us, there's a lot of games and the boys played a lot of football already."

Liverpool, who host Premier League leaders Arsenal on Saturday with a chance to leapfrog the London side, will face Fulham in the first leg of the two-legged League Cup semi-final in the week beginning January 8.

Middlesbrough will take on Chelsea in the other last-four tie.

Barca triumph

Barcelona ground out an unconvincing 3-2 home win against basement club Almeria on Wednesday thanks to a late Sergi Roberto goal, moving them up to third in La Liga.

Xavi Hernandez's side ended 2023 with a win thanks to Sergi Roberto's double and a first-half goal from Raphinha.

Twice the 20th-placed visitors pegged back the Catalan giants courtesy of goals from Leo Baptistao and Edgar Gonzalez but it was eventually the home team who held out to claim the spoils.

Later, Athletic Bilbao went level on points with fourth-place Atletico Madrid after beating Las Palmas 1-0 and near the foot of the table, Rafael Benitez's Celta Vigo lost 3-2 at Villarreal.

PSG on top

Kylian Mbappe marked his 25th birthday with a brace as Paris Saint-Germain beat Metz 3-1 in Ligue 1 on Wednesday to reach the halfway stage of the season five points clear at the top of the table.

PSG, who had been held 1-1 at Lille at the weekend, laboured in the first half before Vitinha opened the scoring early in the second half by turning in a cross from Lee Kang-in. Mbappe then took centre stage by making it 2-0 with a superb strike in off the underside of the crossbar from the edge of the area.

Matthieu Udol pulled one back for the struggling visitors but Mbappe pounced on a short backpass to round the goalkeeper and make it 3-1 towards the end for his 18th league goal of the campaign.

PSG end the year with a comfortable five-point cushion over nearest challengers Nice, who defeated Lens 2-0 on Wednesday thanks to two late goals from Nigerian striker Terem Moffi.

Monaco are seven points behind the leaders in third place after coming from behind to win 2-1 at Toulouse, with Wissam Ben Yedder scoring both of their goals.



PRINCE, PRAFUL, ABHAYA ADVANCE



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Prince Dahal, Praful Maharjan, and Abhaya Mahara have made it to the quarterfinals of the 2nd Mayor Cup National Badminton Tournament in Lalitpur. Praful, who represents Tribhuvan Army Club (TAC), defeated Aman Maharjan from APF with a score of 21-8 and 21-4. APF's Prince advanced to the quarterfinals by beating Sunil Karki of Unity Badminton Academy with a score of 21-15 and 21-9.

Abhaya, also from TAC, made it to the last eight by defeating Kshitiz Khanal from APF Club with a score of 21-15 and 21-13. He also reached the quarterfinals of the U17 boy's singles category.

Bishnu Katuwal and Jeevan Acharya from Nepal Police Club, Dev Rana and Roshan Saud from APF Club, and David Tgaoa Nagar from TAC have also made it to the quarterfinals of the event, which is organized by Lalitpur Badminton Association and sponsored by Lalitpur Metropolitan City.

In the U17 boy's category, Subin Shrestha A (TAC), Suprim Panth (TAC), Rajesh BC (Nepalgunj), Jenish Sherchan (Gulmi), Subin Shrestha B (TAC), Arun Adhikari (APF), and Kabir KC (TAC) have progressed to the quarterfinals.

EU court: FIFA and UEFA defy competition law

REUTERS
Brussels, Dec. 21

UEFA and FIFA contravened EU law by preventing the formation of a Super League, the European Court of Justice said on Thursday, in a landmark ruling that could change the way football is run.

The European soccer clubs that had threatened to form the breakaway league, which sparked widespread protests among angry fans, had been threatened with sanctions by UEFA if they went ahead with the plan, leading to nine clubs pulling out.

In its ruling, the EU's top court said that FIFA and UEFA abused their dominant position by forbidding clubs to compete in a European Super League (ESL), although that project may still not be approved as the court did not rule on it specifically.

UEFA has organised pan-European competitions for nearly 70 years and sees the ESL project as a significant threat to the lucrative Champions League, for which teams qualify on merit.

Real Madrid, Barcelona and Juventus and nine other European heavyweights announced the breakaway closed ESL in April 2021.

But the move collapsed within 48 hours after an outcry from fans, governments and players forced Manchester United, Liverpool, Manchester City, Chelsea, Tottenham Hotspur, Arsenal, AC Milan, Inter Milan and Atletico Madrid to pull out.

Sports development company A22, which was formed to assist with creating the ESL, had claimed UEFA and global soccer governing body FIFA held a monopoly position which was in breach of the European Union's Competition and Free Movement Law.

"We have won the right to compete. The UEFA-monopoly is over. Football is free," said A22 CEO Bernd Reichart.

"Clubs are now free from the threat of sanction and free to determine their own futures," Reichard added in a statement.

UEFA said the ruling did not signify an endorsement or validation of the Super League and that it had addressed a shortfall that had been highlighted in its own framework.

"UEFA is confident in the robustness of its new rules, and specifically that they comply with all relevant European laws and regulations," it added in a statement.

FIFA did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:51 am, Sunset at 5:14 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy to mainly fair throughout the country.

Expected Temp.: 17 - 19°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	18.2	4.3	0.0
Dipayal	23.8	5.5	0.0
Dhangadi	25.8	8.8	0.0
Birendranagar	22.9	6.2	0.0
Nepalgunj	24.8	9.8	0.0
Jumla	20.2	-2.8	0.0
Ghorahi	22.6	8.1	0.0
Pokhara	21.8	7.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	25.0	7.3	0.0
Simara	25.9	8.0	0.0
Kathmandu	19.3	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.6	8.3	0.0
Taplejung	18.7	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	23.5	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	26.4	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	18.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	26.1	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	6.8	0.0*
Janakpur	29.0	9.5	0.0*
Jiri	18.5	0.0	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 22, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.95	Rs. 133.55
Euro	1	Rs. 145.79	Rs. 146.44
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.31	Rs. 169.07
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.45	Rs. 155.15
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 89.74	Rs. 90.15
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.62	Rs. 100.07
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.98	Rs. 100.44
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.30	Rs. 9.34
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.60	Rs. 18.68
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.44	Rs. 35.60
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.47	Rs. 36.64
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.81	Rs. 3.83
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.20	Rs. 36.36
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.56	Rs. 28.69
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.19	Rs. 10.23
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.11	Rs. 13.17
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.55	Rs. 19.64
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.02	Rs. 17.10
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.43	Rs. 434.38
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.63	Rs. 354.23

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

In the presence of President Ramchandra Paudel, Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha administering the oath of office and secrecy to the newly appointed justices of the Supreme Court at Presidential Building, Sheetal Niwas in Kathmandu on Thursday.

Scrap licenses held without initiating project work: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation to scrap the licenses of those who hold them for hydropower projects but do not proceed ahead the works.

Speaking at a joint review meeting of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation and Ministry of Communication and Information Technology held at the Office of the Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda gave this instruction.

The Prime Minister said, "The practice of carrying a river in bags has been in news headlines for a long time. Taking a license and holding it but not working is suicidal for the country. We do not have to be flexible. Such licenses should be scrapped by creating certain criteria."

"The tax system should be organised by cutting the electricity lines of the big ones who do not pay electricity dues," said PM Prachanda, "Do not compromise with anyone. Let's immediately disconnect the lines of non-paying dedicated and trunk lines. Start with the big ones and go towards collecting all the tariff dues."

He said that an irrigation system is necessary for production increase, and we should also think about lift irrigation.

"We should think about long-term management of irrigation by connecting the river system," said the Prime Minister, adding, "The problem of irrigation is also deeply connected with agriculture. Let's do the necessary homework in this direction to increase the productivity of agriculture."

"One year has passed since the formation of the present government under my leadership, next year, we are going in a new way," he said, "For that, let's change our thinking, let's change the way we work."

"I am serious about listening to the ministry, understanding and producing better results. I am changing the way of working, think about what you will do for the country and the people and move forward with determination. As we continue to do good, those with evil intentions are exposed. Let's do it that way."

In the meeting, Prime Minister Prachanda instructed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology to simplify the policy related to advertising and to think about protecting the communication industry when

» SEE PAGE 6

NEW JUSTICES TAKE OATH

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Newly appointed six judges of Supreme Court (SC) took an oath of office and secrecy before Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha amidst a programme here on Tuesday. They took the oath in presence of President Ramchandra Paudel at the ceremony held at the Office of the President, Shital Niwas.

The Parliamentary Hearing Committee on Wednesday endorsed the nominations of Saranga Subedi, Abdul Ajij Musalman, Mahesh Sharma Paudel, Tek Prasad Dhungana, Sunil Kumar Pokhrel and Balkrishna Dhakal as the apex court judges and it followed their appointments on the posts by the Head of the State same day.

Today's Supplement Highlight

AI: Shaping Tomorrow, Transforming Today's Reality.



Nepal, Sri Lanka discuss Lumbini-Colombo air connection

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Nepal and Sri Lanka have discussed about the possible air connections between Colombo and Lumbini.

The first meeting of Nepal-Sri Lanka Joint Commission (JC) that began in Kathmandu on Thursday take a note that the start of Kathmandu-Colombo air connection was encouraging and talked about further cooperation in aviation and other sectors, informed the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) of Nepal.

Nepal is looking for options to bring in Buddhist pilgrims and tourists directly to Lumbini, the birthplace of Lord Buddha, through the Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa. However, formal discussions are being made with China, Myanmar, Thailand and Sri Lanka in the first phase.

Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, NP Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart, M. U. M. Ali Sabry are leading the delegation of their country to the meeting that will run untill Friday. The Sri Lankan delegation led by its Foreign Minister Sabry arrived Kathmandu on Wednesday.

Two Ministers shared about the serious impacts of climate change faced by the respective country. They emphasized the need of climate justice, early operationalization of loss and damage fund, and more international support to combat the impacts of climate change in countries like Nepal and Sri Lanka.

The two countries also signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Cooperation in the Field of Science, Technology and Innovation. The Ministry of Education, Science and Technology of Nepal and the Ministry of Education of Sri Lanka signed and exchanged the MoU at the meeting.

Likewise, the two ministers exchanged thoughts on the possibility of transferring the three Nepali nationals imprisoned in Sri Lanka. They also discussed about the exchanges in culture, tourism and education sectors, regional cooperation including strengthening SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) and BIMSTEC processes, and cooperation in multilateral forums.

Nepali delegation to the meeting includes Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal, Ambassador of Nepal to Sri Lanka Basudev Mishra, and senior officials from ministries of Commerce, Home and Foreign Affairs.

Sri Lanka delegation includes Ambassador of Sri Lanka in Kathmandu Sudarshana Pathirana and senior officials of their Foreign Ministry.

Earlier today, Foreign Minister of Sri Lanka paid a courtesy call on Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at his office in Singha Durbar. On the occasion, discussions were held on matters of mutual interest between Nepal and Sri Lanka, the MoFA said in a statement.

During the visit, the Minister Sabry is also scheduled to pay courtesy calls on President of Nepal, Ramchandra Poudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, the MoFA said.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart M. U. M. Ali Sabry holding a bilateral talk in Kathmnadu on Thursday.

Castes with less than 0.5% population to be listed as minorities

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The government has decided that the castes whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population will be classified as minorities.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Thursday in Singha Durbar designated the minority castes for Clause (b) of Section 2 of the National Assembly Member Election Act 2019.

Talking to the media after the Cabinet meeting, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said, "The meeting has decided that each caste whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population as per the National Census-2021 will be listed as minorities."

Minister Sharma, who is also the government Spokesperson said, "Castes belonging to the Dalit community will not be included in such list."

The meeting also decided to approve the guidelines for the use of social media by government offices-2023 submitted by the social committee of the Cabinet and approved the national policy for persons with disabilities.

Similarly, the meeting also approved the National Children's Policy-2022.

Meanwhile, as per the Cabinet decision, the government has released Rs. 10 million to provide compensation of Rs. 1 million each to 10 individuals who got killed during the Hamas attack in Israel on October 7 this year.

Deuba urges party workers to make NC victorious in next election

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpurdham, Dec. 21



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has urged the party rank and file to work in such a way that the party will be victorious by securing a majority in the next election.

Inaugurating the first conference of the party's Madhes Province in Janakpurdham on Thursday, Deuba urged the party's Madhes Committee to work to win majority seats in the next poll.

NC general secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa said the NC need not to fear with anyone as theirs was the largest party in the Federal Parliament and a party that had promulgated the constitution.

He underlined the need for giving more opportunity to women, Dalits and Muslims by increasing their participation in the party.

Stressing the need for warning the leaders who abused the electoral system, Thapa said that NC should fulfill the duty of maintaining good governance as the party was leading 332 local governments.

He urged the party leadership to look at history. "There are evidences that BP Koirala succeeded to perform works within 24 months which had not been done before in 200 years. If the NC works in the provinces and local levels where it is leading the governments without any discrimination and without involving in corruption, the party will win the next elections," he said. He also urged the party leaders to maintain unity in the party.

NC joint general secretary Mahendra Yadav said that federalism would become weak if NC became weak.

Urging to strength the NC to strengthen the federalism, Yadav urged the Chief Minister of Madhes to perform as per the spirit of the coalition.

In the conference held under the chairmanship of NC Madhes Province Committee chair Krishna Prasad Yadav, NC vice president and Deputy Prime Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka and others also aired their views.

No functional hospitals left in northern Gaza: WHO

AFP
Geneva, Dec. 21

There are no longer any functional hospitals in the north of the Gaza Strip, the World Health Organization said Thursday, describing "unbearable" scenes of largely abandoned patients begging for food and water.

The UN health agency said it had led missions to two badly damaged hospitals, Al-Shifa and Al-Ahli, in the north of the Palestinian territory on Wednesday.

"Our staff are running out of words to describe the beyond catastrophic situation facing remaining patients and health workers," said Richard Peeperkorn, the WHO representative for the occupied Palestinian territory.

His comment came amid increasingly frantic diplomatic efforts to secure a pause in the war that Hamas says has already claimed 20,000 lives in Gaza, 70 percent of them women and children.

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He reiterated the increasingly urgent call for a ceasefire to allow sufficient amounts of aid in and also to evacuate more patients from Gaza.

Asked when whether time was running out, he said: "I think it is (already) too late.

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NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

In the presence of President Ramchandra Paudel, Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha administering the oath of office and secrecy to the newly appointed justices of the Supreme Court at Presidential Building, Sheetal Niwas in Kathmandu on Thursday.

Scrap licenses held without initiating project work: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation to scrap the licenses of those who hold them for hydropower projects but do not proceed ahead the works.

Speaking at a joint review meeting of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation and Ministry of Communication and Information Technology held at the Office of the Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda gave this instruction.

The Prime Minister said, "The practice of carrying a river in bags has been in news headlines for a long time. Taking a license and holding it but not working is suicidal for the country. We do not have to be flexible. Such licenses should be scrapped by creating certain criteria."

"The tax system should be organised by cutting the electricity lines of the big ones who do not pay electricity dues," said PM Prachanda, "Do not compromise with anyone. Let's immediately disconnect the lines of non-paying dedicated and trunk lines. Start with the big ones and go towards collecting all the tariff dues."

He said that an irrigation system is necessary for production increase, and we should also think about lift irrigation.

"We should think about long-term management of irrigation by connecting the river system," said the Prime Minister, adding, "The problem of irrigation is also deeply connected with agriculture. Let's do the necessary homework in this direction to increase the productivity of agriculture."

"One year has passed since the formation of the present government under my leadership, next year, we are going in a new way," he said, "For that, let's change our thinking, let's change the way we work."

"I am serious about listening to the ministry, understanding and producing better results. I am changing the way of working, think about what you will do for the country and the people and move forward with determination. As we continue to do good, those with evil intentions are exposed. Let's do it that way."

In the meeting, Prime Minister Prachanda instructed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology to simplify the policy related to advertising and to think about protecting the communication industry when

» SEE PAGE 6

NEW JUSTICES TAKE OATH

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Newly appointed six judges of Supreme Court (SC) took an oath of office and secrecy before Chief Justice Bishowambhar Prasad Shrestha amidst a programme here on Tuesday. They took the oath in presence of President Ramchandra Paudel at the ceremony held at the Office of the President, Shital Niwas.

The Parliamentary Hearing Committee on Wednesday endorsed the nominations of Saranga Subedi, Abdul Ajij Musalman, Mahesh Sharma Paudel, Tek Prasad Dhungana, Sunil Kumar Pokhrel and Balkrishna Dhakal as the apex court judges and it followed their appointments on the posts by the Head of the State same day.

Today's Supplement Highlight

AI: Shaping Tomorrow, Transforming Today's Reality.



Nepal, Sri Lanka discuss Lumbini-Colombo air connection

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

Nepal and Sri Lanka have discussed about the possible air connections between Colombo and Lumbini.

The first meeting of Nepal-Sri Lanka Joint Commission (JC) that began in Kathmandu on Thursday take a note that the start of Kathmandu-Colombo air connection was encouraging and talked about further cooperation in aviation and other sectors, informed the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) of Nepal.

Nepal is looking for options to bring in Buddhist pilgrims and tourists directly to Lumbini, the birthplace of Lord Buddha, through the Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa. However, formal discussions are being made with China, Myanmar, Thailand and Sri Lanka in the first phase.

Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, NP Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart, M. U. M. Ali Sabry are leading the delegation of their country to the meeting that will run untill Friday. The Sri Lankan delegation led by its Foreign Minister Sabry arrived Kathmandu on Wednesday.

Two Ministers shared about the serious impacts of climate change faced by the respective country. They emphasized the need of climate justice, early operationalization of loss and damage fund, and more international support to combat the impacts of climate change in countries like Nepal and Sri Lanka.

The two countries also signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Cooperation in the Field of Science, Technology and Innovation. The Ministry of Education, Science and Technology of Nepal and the Ministry of Education of Sri Lanka signed and exchanged the MoU at the meeting.

Likewise, the two ministers exchanged thoughts on the possibility of transferring the three Nepali nationals imprisoned in Sri Lanka. They also discussed about the exchanges in culture, tourism and education sectors, regional cooperation including strengthening SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) and BIMSTEC processes, and cooperation in multilateral forums.

Nepali delegation to the meeting includes Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal, Ambassador of Nepal to Sri Lanka Basudev Mishra, and senior officials from ministries of Commerce, Home and Foreign Affairs.

Sri Lanka delegation includes Ambassador of Sri Lanka in Kathmandu Sudarshana Pathirana and senior officials of their Foreign Ministry.

Earlier today, Foreign Minister of Sri Lanka paid a courtesy call on Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at his office in Singha Durbar. On the occasion, discussions were held on matters of mutual interest between Nepal and Sri Lanka, the MoFA said in a statement.

During the visit, the Minister Sabry is also scheduled to pay courtesy calls on President of Nepal, Ramchandra Poudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, the MoFA said.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud and his Sri Lankan counterpart M. U. M. Ali Sabry holding a bilateral talk in Kathmnadu on Thursday.

Castes with less than 0.5% population to be listed as minorities

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 21

The government has decided that the castes whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population will be classified as minorities.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Thursday in Singha Durbar designated the minority castes for Clause (b) of Section 2 of the National Assembly Member Election Act 2019.

Talking to the media after the Cabinet meeting, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said, "The meeting has decided that each caste whose population is less than 0.5 per cent of the total population as per the National Census-2021 will be listed as minorities."

Minister Sharma, who is also the government Spokesperson said, "Castes belonging to the Dalit community will not be included in such list."

The meeting also decided to approve the guidelines for the use of social media by government offices-2023 submitted by the social committee of the Cabinet and approved the national policy for persons with disabilities.

Similarly, the meeting also approved the National Children's Policy-2022.

Meanwhile, as per the Cabinet decision, the government has released Rs. 10 million to provide compensation of Rs. 1 million each to 10 individuals who got killed during the Hamas attack in Israel on October 7 this year.

Deuba urges party workers to make NC victorious in next election

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpurdham, Dec. 21



Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has urged the party rank and file to work in such a way that the party will be victorious by securing a majority in the next election.

Inaugurating the first conference of the party's Madhes Province in Janakpurdham on Thursday, Deuba urged the party's Madhes Committee to work to win majority seats in the next poll.

NC general secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa said the NC need not to fear with anyone as theirs was the largest party in the Federal Parliament and a party that had promulgated the constitution.

He underlined the need for giving more opportunity to women, Dalits and Muslims by increasing their participation in the party.

Stressing the need for warning the leaders who abused the electoral system, Thapa said that NC should fulfill the duty of maintaining good governance as the party was leading 332 local governments.

He urged the party leadership to look at history. "There are evidences that BP Koirala succeeded to perform works within 24 months which had not been done before in 200 years. If the NC works in the provinces and local levels where it is leading the governments without any discrimination and without involving in corruption, the party will win the next elections," he said. He also urged the party leaders to maintain unity in the party.

NC joint general secretary Mahendra Yadav said that federalism would become weak if NC became weak.

Urging to strength the NC to strengthen the federalism, Yadav urged the Chief Minister of Madhes to perform as per the spirit of the coalition.

In the conference held under the chairmanship of NC Madhes Province Committee chair Krishna Prasad Yadav, NC vice president and Deputy Prime Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka and others also aired their views.

No functional hospitals left in northern Gaza: WHO

AFP
Geneva, Dec. 21

There are no longer any functional hospitals in the north of the Gaza Strip, the World Health Organization said Thursday, describing "unbearable" scenes of largely abandoned patients begging for food and water.

The UN health agency said it had led missions to two badly damaged hospitals, Al-Shifa and Al-Ahli, in the north of the Palestinian territory on Wednesday.

"Our staff are running out of words to describe the beyond catastrophic situation facing remaining patients and health workers," said Richard Peeperkorn, the WHO representative for the occupied Palestinian territory.

His comment came amid increasingly frantic diplomatic efforts to secure a pause in the war that Hamas says has already claimed 20,000 lives in Gaza, 70 percent of them women and children.

The war began when Hamas attacked Israel on October 7, killing around 1,140 people, mostly civilians, and abducting about 250, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

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> There are no operating theatres anymore due to the lack of fuel, power, medical supplies and health workers, including surgeons and other specialists.

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- Dying 'slowly and painfully' -

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"There are no operating theatres anymore due to the lack of fuel, power, medical supplies and health workers, including surgeons and other specialists," he added.

"It has completely stopped functioning."

Of Gaza's original 36 hospitals, only nine are now partially functional, all of them in the south.

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Hospitals, protected under international humanitarian law, have repeatedly been hit by Israeli strikes in Gaza since the war erupted.

The Israeli military accuses Hamas of having tunnels under hospitals and using the medical facilities as command centres, a charge denied by the Islamist group.

Asked about the charge, Peeperkorn said "we on our missions have not seen anything of this on the ground", adding that WHO was "not in a position to assert how any hospital is being used".

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But that was not enough, he said.

"Without fuel, staff, and other essential needs, medicines won't make a difference and all patients will die slowly and painfully."

Al Ahli, he said, still counts around 10 staff striving to provide basic first aid, while around 80 patients are sheltering in a church within the hospital grounds and the orthopaedic section.

- 'Too late' -

Sean Casey, a WHO Emergency Medical Teams coordinator who was on the mission, described "unbelievable conditions".

At Al Ahli, the team had walked through the courtyard, where bodies wrapped in white plastic sheeting piled up, and with automatic gunfire sounding nearby, he told journalists, speaking from Rafah in southern Gaza.

In the church, "we found a really unbearable scene," Casey said, describing around 30 patients, including young children and some with serious trauma wounds begging, not for care but for water.

"At the moment, it is a place where people are waiting to die."

He reiterated the increasingly urgent call for a ceasefire to allow sufficient amounts of aid in and also to evacuate more patients from Gaza.

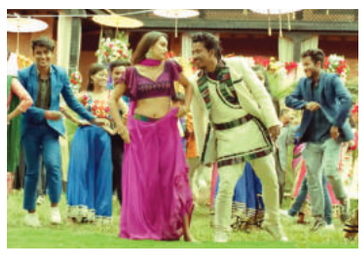
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Friday, December 22, 2023
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How AI Is Revolutionising The World



Kishor Basyal

Artificial intelligence (AI) allows computers to learn and solve problems like human beings. It is reshaping the world in significant ways, transforming industries, changing the nature of work, revolutionising how we interact with technology, and profoundly impacting every aspect of our lives. AI's influence has become so pervasive that it is altering the way we live, work, and communicate. Its miraculous ability to automate jobs, analyse vast amounts of data, and make predictions is changing our society in ways only a very few technologies did in the past. Today, AI has become too important to ignore. This article is about the key areas being transformed by AI and the concerns, challenges, and solutions in the brave new world dominated by it. As AI develops at lightning speed with every passing day, being able to keep up means staying ahead of the competition and relevant.



Key areas

Let's start with healthcare. The COVID-19 pandemic became so deadly because of the lack of a vaccine that could defang the coronavirus. And it took months for the scientists to come up with the vaccine. But AI is making vaccine and drug discovery easier, more efficient, more effective, and less resource-consuming. How? AI-powered tools like machine learning help in designing molecules with specific properties, optimising their structures for efficacy and safety, and accelerating the drug development process.



Besides, AI analyses biological data to predict how a drug might interact with various biological targets, helping to understand potential side effects and optimise drugs. AI assists in designing more efficient clinical trials by analysing vast amounts of data, identifying suitable patient populations, and predicting potential outcomes, reducing the time and costs involved in trials. It also improves their effectiveness and streamlines the process, leading to faster and more cost-effective treatments for various diseases. Similarly, AI algorithms analyse chemical structures and predict the likelihood of a disease, enabling us to take early precautionary measures.

Transportation is another area that is being transformed by AI. Autonomous vehicles, such as self-driving cars, trucks, and drones, are increasingly using sensor data from cameras and radar, among other sensors, to navigate roads, interpret surroundings, and make intelligent driving decisions on the go, improving road safety and efficiency.

Also, AI algorithms analyse traffic patterns, predict traffic snarls and congestion, and optimise traffic flow, making traffic management smarter. Making matters sweeter, AI-driven apps provide the best routes and up-to-date traffic conditions, enhancing the travel experience. AI's integration into transportation is making the industry safer, more efficient, and more convenient for both passengers and transport entrepreneurs.

AI is revolutionising customer care. AI-powered chatbots handle customer inquiries, provide instant responses, and assist in getting around common issues 24/7. AI analyses customer data to personalise interactions, offering tailored recommendations, solutions, and support based on individual preferences and behaviors. By harnessing AI technologies, businesses are becoming able to provide efficient, personalised support, enhancing the customer experience and satisfaction.

The profound impact of AI is also being felt in journalism, reshaping how news is reported, produced, disseminated, and consumed. AI-powered tools enable faster reporting, a broader global reach, interactive storytelling formats, personalised news delivery, and data analytics. In addition to aiding in content creation and audience targeting, such tools also assist in fact-checking and detecting misinformation, aiding journalists in ensuring the accuracy of their reports. Besides, they help journalists analyse vast amounts of data quickly, extract valuable insights, and identify trends, bringing investigative journalism and date-driven storytelling within reach.

Similarly, AI-equipped natural language processing (NLP) technology helps in language translation, sentiment analysis, and understanding audience feedback, empowering journalists to connect with readers, viewers, and audiences of all stripes. Automated transcription and translation facilities quick transcription and translation of interviews, making content more accessible and enabling journalists to cover stories in multiple languages efficiently. AI-driven, enhanced multimedia storytelling can contribute to creating interactive and immersive storytelling experiences through technologies like virtual reality and augmented reality.

AI can analyse vast amounts of data and produce articles related to financial reports and weather forecasts, among other data-driven stories, in no time, freeing journalists from the shackles of time to focus on more in-depth reporting and helping them notice stories and insights that might otherwise go undiscovered. After observing customers' preferences and behaviours for some time, AI algorithms are increasingly able to deliver news feeds tailored to a particular customer.

AI is also changing the way news organisations interact with their audiences. They are using chatbots and voice interfaces to deliver news updates, answer questions, and provide personalised recommendations. This not only offers a more convenient and engaging way for users to consume news but also opens up new revenue sources through targeted advertising.

Challenges and solutions

At the same time, AI has raised several concerns, such as bias and ethics. When an AI algorithm learns from biassed data or is trained on datasets rife with biassed information, it can perpetuate and even magnify those biases. That makes it prone to mistakes. Who will be answerable when an AI system does harm with legal implications? is a question many are confronted with. What's more, there is a growing fear that AI will displace humans from jobs in a world where unemployment is already high.

Addressing these concerns requires collaboration among researchers, policymakers, ethicists, and technologists to develop frameworks and guidelines for responsible AI development and deployment. The good news is that there is a growing recognition that AI is a force for good and that it can vastly boost productivity and add trillions of dollars in value to the global economy. No matter how much AI gets better at everything, it is still nowhere near matching the unique features humans are endowed with, like creativity, empathy, intellectual reasoning, and emotional understanding. While it may change job requirements, AI also creates new job opportunities in AI development, data science, and professions that require skills in unique human qualities. So, instead of fretting about the potential job loss, what we can do is prepare ourselves for the jobs AI is incapable of taking over.

(Basyal works as a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

Thamel: A Cultural Commerce Hub



Sahadev Dhamala

Nestled at the heart of Kathmandu, Thamel has long been the epicentre of the city's tourist industry, drawing artists and travellers from all corners of the globe since the "hippie era."

Its labyrinthine alleys hum with a vibrant blend of shops and vendors offering an array of goods, such as food, vegetables, pastries, trekking gear, music, handicrafts, and clothing. Beyond its bustling marketplace, Thamel hosts travel agencies, budget hotels, restaurants, pubs, and clubs, catering to the diverse needs of visitors.

Importantly, it serves as a pre-base camp for mountaineers and has essential services such as mountaineering gear stores, which support their various adventure packages. Thamel's renowned nightlife brims with restaurants, cafés, and live music venues, frequented by tourists and locals alike.

Situated near Pratayan Marha, Bhagabati Marga, Chasksibari Marga, Kwabahal, JP Road, Paknajol, and Sanchaya Kosh Road, it is a bustling tourist district with its five main streets and numerous smaller ones spanning major Kathmandu metropolitan wards 16, 26, 17, and 27. This vibrant hub serves as a convenient base for travellers, often being their first stop after arriving at the airport and easily finding accommodation.

Thamel's roots delve deep into history. The Newars initially inhabited a modest settlement in the northern part of the Kathmandu city area. Cantered on a Newar Buddhist monastery called Bhagwan Bahal, also known as Than Bahil in the Newari language, Thamel's connection to the northern section of the city is evident.

The southern part of Thamel, densely populated by long-established Newar residents, acted as a dividing line between the inner core and the outskirts of the city. During the era of the hippie boom in Jhoche, Thamel was a single street, spanning approximately 20 to 30 metres.

However, the 1980s ushered in mass tourism, attracting budget-conscious tourists and backpackers. This transformation marked a shift from a residential area to a bustling tourism precinct, offering new business opportunities for local residents and entrepreneurs. This eventually transformed Thamel into a renowned business district within the tourism industry.

Despite its prominence, Thamel faces challenges. The decline in tourism in the wake of the COVID pandemic has left its mark, leading to the closure and bankruptcy of many hotels. Consequentially, local residents are now frequenting Thamel to experience and embrace different cultures.

Rich heritage

Thamel is steeped in history. The central pagoda pays tribute to the legendary merchant Singha Sarthabahu from "Dwapar Yug," who embarked on a trade journey from Kathmandu to Tibet, a story well-known throughout East Asia.

The Pradhans, one of the Newar clans, consider him their ancestor and worship the main idol as Singha Sarthabahu. The Pradhan dynasty cares for this Bahal, unlike other Bahals in the Kathmandu Valley. Typically, Newar tribes maintain Bihars or temples, run or maintained by Bajracharya, Shakya, or Tuladhars.

Challenges

While Thamel remains a prominent tourism hub in Kathmandu, the recent decline in tourism due to the COVID outbreak has taken its toll, leading to the closure and bankruptcy of many hotels. Consequentially, local residents have turned to Thamel to experience and embrace different cultures.



Current Thamel is known for its lively nightlife, and this can result in excessive noise that persists well into the early hours of the morning. If you are a light sleeper or prefer a quiet environment, the noise can be a significant issue for all hotels and residents. Narrow streets often become congested with vehicles, making it challenging to navigate and leading to air pollution. Thamel is primarily a commercial area, and there is a shortage of open space or green spaces for relaxation and recreation. The air quality in Thamel is often poor due to traffic emissions and construction activities.

And Thamel can become quite crowded during the night with young teenagers, making it difficult to enjoy a peaceful and leisurely exploration of the area. Overcrowding also means they create noise and unhealthy environments in Nepal.

While street vendors and hawkers contribute to the area's charm, some tourists find the constant solicitation and haggling overwhelming and exhausting. Thamel also struggles with effective waste management, which can lead to littered streets and an unappealing environment. Like many tourist areas, Thamel has its share of touts and scammers who may try to overcharge or mislead tourists. It's essential to remain vigilant and informed to avoid falling victim to such practices.

Tourism scenario

Tourism plays a pivotal role in generating government revenue and has positive impacts on various sectors of the economy. But the pandemic severely affected international tourism.

Developed countries have long recognised tourism as a vital economic component, while developing countries are now also realising the benefits of tourism. The Nepalese government must now focus on promoting destinations such as Thamel to harness the full potential of tourism. Tourism in Thamel brings several advantages, including a source of foreign currency, conservation of art and culture, increased trade, employment opportunities, and global publicity.

Current challenges

Despite an increase in foreign tourists visiting the area, local businesses have not seen the expected growth, with business at its lowest point. Trade levels have reached only 20 percent of pre-pandemic levels. This decline in business activity can be attributed to a lack of high-spending tourists.

On the other hand, hoteliers in Thamel have reported increased occupancy rates, although tourists tend to limit their stays to one or two days. The aviation and trekking sectors have also witnessed a rise in tourist numbers.

Master plan

To revive Thamel as a bustling tourism hub and safeguard the interests of its almost 9500 businesses and 2700 property owners, a comprehensive tourism master plan is essential. This master plan should encompass and formulate such issues. Research and assessment of the region, identifying strengths and weaknesses, sustainable tourism practices that minimise negative impacts, development of necessary infrastructure, marketing and promotion strategies, preservation of cultural heritage, and collaboration with local stakeholders. Conclusion

Thamel deserves a sustainable future. A well-planned tourism master plan can rekindle its status as a thriving tourist destination, benefiting both businesses and the local community. By embracing sustainable practices, preserving cultural heritage, and investing in infrastructure and promotion, Thamel can reclaim its position as an iconic tourism hub, contributing to Nepal's economic growth and cultural diversity.

(The author is a vice president of the Thamel Tourism Development Council)

Influence Of Buddhism In Dolakha



Dr. Shyam Joshi

Dolakha was a separate state before the unification of Nepal by King Prithivi Narayan Shah. Although Dolakha was always a settlement of Hindus ruled by Hindu kings, there are temples and festivals related to Buddhism as well. It shows that Dolakha was a religiously neutral state from time immemorial, when it was a state. Perhaps Dolakha is the only place in the whole of Nepal where only Newars live within the city. The priest of Machindranath with the Bajracharya surname is the only family of the Buddhist religion living inside the town. The kings of Dolakha, including the king Indrasigh Dev, who had brought silver coins into circulation even before Mahendra Malla, the king of Kantipur, sought to make its culture more vibrant by integrating the festivals of both Hinduism and Buddhism.

Buddhist chaityas

The king Jayanarayan had installed five Buddhist chaityas, called "Seng" in the local language, inside Dolakha by bringing Bajracharya from Kantipur, which is regarded as the symbol of Buddha. The people of Dolakha, while going to pay homage to Lord Bhimeswor early in the morning, do not miss to revolve around the Chaitya and make darshan of the statues of Buddha located in four corners of the Chaitya in the Upper Tole of Dolakha. Till now, no Hindu, out of prejudice, has heard of saying, "That's not our god.".

It is said that although Buddha did not believe in God, he used to give sermons on divine qualities like truth, love, and harmony. He was the superman among all of mankind. Hence, it is no wonder that the people of Dolakha worship the statues of Buddha despite being Hindus.

Dharma Dhatu Chaitya, located in Upper Tole, was established by the then ruler of Dolakha Jainarayan Dev, the brother of King Indrasingh Dev and his queen Bittalakshmi, in 1606 AD (Nepal Sambat 669). The statues of Buddha in different postures have been placed in the four corners of the Chaitya. The maintenance of this chaitya was made from the revenues collected in haat bazar at that time. The Buddhist chaitya of Nakchhe Tole has been built in the style of the Swayambhu of Kathmandu. According to Ratna Kazi Bajracharya, Sri Ratna Muni Bajracharya of Patan had renovated the chaityas of Kotchhe and Dungal toles. At that time, Ratna Muni Bajracharya was the Thakali of Patan's Mantra Siddhi Mahavihar. These show that at that time, the Hindu rulers of Dolakha had some inclinations towards Buddhism.

Buddhist bihar

There are two toles to the north and south of the present Dharmadhatu Chaitya located in the upper Tole: the "Thata Biharchhey" (Upper Bihar House) and the Kota Biharchhey (Lower Bihar House). Hence, historians imagine that once there were Buddhists in Bihar. However, there is no sign or remains of neither Bihar nor monks. Ratna Kazi Bajracharya mentioned in one of his articles that there is actual Bihar in those toles. He writes, "According to the brothers of Patan's Mantra Siddhi Bihar, the grandfather of Ratna Muni, Bajracharya of Sobal Bihar, Saubal of Patan, had gone to build a Bihar and live in a country called Dolakha. Bihar is a place where monks reside, take rest, practice meditation, and acquire knowledge.

It might be due to the lack of Bihar that there were no statues of Buddha in Dolakha. However, in Shyamsundar Tole, there is a stone statue of Dipankar Buddha without a temple and the date of installment. Only on October 23, 21, Dr. Sunil Maskey established Sri Padambarna Buddha Mahavihara and installed the statue of Buddha in his Tole Palchuti, Dolakha, in the memory of his deceased parents. So, now we can see the actual Buddha Bihar in Dolakha. According to the available evidence, there used to be cultural exchange between Patan and Dolakha at that time. Because the king of Dolakha Shri Ujot Deb, during his visit to Lalitpur to establish friendly relations in Nepal, Sambat 653 (B.S. 1589), had offered a golden idol of god and two large bells to Patan's Hiranyabarna Mahabihar.

Revolve around temples.

The kings of Dolakha, who developed the rich culture in Kathmandu Valley, introduced their own type of "Gulna uiri," or revolving around the temples of Dolakha town, during the Hile Jatra festival. In Kathmandu, mainly the Buddhists revolve around the Buddhist Chaityas for one month, playing musical instruments during the Gulna festival (the Hile Jatra). However, in Dolakha, Hindus revolve around and worship all temples in the town by playing local musical instruments. These temples include the temples of Hindu deities as well as the Buddhist chaityas, or Swayambhu.

Starting from Shrawan Sukla Parewa, the separate gulna parikramaa groups of upper and lower Toles play traditional local music and revolve around almost all temples in Dolakha every morning on a regular basis. Along with a group of musicians, a priest carries a puja plate and performs puja in each temple. Thus, the practice of revolving around the temples is known as "Gulna Huya," which ends only on the day of Kage Astami. It is believed that if chaityas are revolved throughout this month, not only the dead are freed of their sins, but the country is also relieved of the disease, pandemic, and sufferings.

Obviously, Gulna Huya customs in Dolakha are different from those in Kathmandu. Traditionally, in Kathmandu, only Buddhist Newars revolve around Buddhist Chaityas. However, only Hindu Newars revolve around both Buddhist stupas and Hindu temples in Dolakha without any prejudice. This shows that the Newars of Dolakha were more liberal than those of the Kathmandu Valley.





> Since the priest of Machhindranath is Gubhaju, the festival looks like the festival of Buddhists. However, in Dolakha, this festival is celebrated with great enthusiasm by the general public, mostly Hindus.

donated it to the Panchadan festival as per the teachings of the Buddha. The Buddhist children as well as the elderly go around and receive panchadan alms in different forms.

In Dolakha, "Panchadan" is given to the Bajracharyas who go around the town playing musical instruments during the festival called "Pangja." Besides giving donations, food is also served to them. The tradition of giving alms and feasting in Banda Jatra dates back to the year 1857 B.S. But there is a slight difference between Valley and Dolakha from the perspective of the festival participants. In the Kathmandu valley, both those who receive and give donations are basically Buddhists. However, in Dolakha, Buddhist Bajracharyas take alms, and Hindu Newars give alms. It might be because there is only one Buddhist family in Dolakha.

The festival begins on the day of Bhadrakrishna Trayodasi, and Panchdan is given in every Tole and chaitya for three days. Although there are only one or two Buddhist Bajracharya families in Dolakha, the "Baada Jaatra" is celebrated here. This clearly indicates that the rulers of Dolakha also used to give equal respect to the customs and traditions of the Buddhists.

Rato Machhindranath

The festival of red Machhindranath, the god of rain, is celebrated only in Dolakha town, outside Kathmandu Valley. It is believed that Machhindranath was installed in Bungamati, Patan, in 632 B.S. to make rainfall to get relief from a long drought. A Bajracharya of Patan brought the same red Machhindranath to Dolakha from Bungamati in 1575 B.S. The idol was then installed in a newly built temple in Dwakulunga Tole. Since at that time Dolakha was a prosperous state, traders from Patan and Bhaktapur used to live in Dolakha for business purposes. As Machhindranath was brought from Bungamati, it is called "Bugdeu" in Dolakha, as in Patan, where "Deu" means god in Dolakha.

The chariot festival of Machhindranath takes place nine days starting from Baisakh Purnima. The chariot is pulled around Dolakha town during the festival. The chariot pull starts and ends at the Pingal Tole after passing through five other important Toles. When the chariot procession starts, thousands of people assemble to observe and worship the god and enjoy pulling the chariot down a seemingly difficult, narrow, and steep hill road.

Since the priest of Machhindranath is Gubhaju, the festival looks like the festival of Buddhists. However, in Dolakha, this festival is celebrated with great enthusiasm by the general public, mostly Hindus.

On the 9th day, when the idol is brought back to the temple in Dwakulunga Tole, Gubhaju, the priest of the temple, worships the god in the courtyard. Then, before taking the god inside the temple, the Gubhaju resides in a sloka, loudly praying to the god to relieve the people and country, including the king, from suffering, and takes the god inside, which ends the festival. It seems that since the temple was established by the Gubhaju of Patan, the sloka is recited in "Nepal Bhasha," or Newari language.



Stone taps

Dolakha has a famous stone tap called Raiti, with three stone taps in a row. Raiti was the lifeline of the residents of Dolakha town until 2019 B.S. In other words, it was the main source of water for all residents until the piped taps were introduced in 2019 B.S. Raiti has a statue of Pashupati in one corner, a statue of Buddha in the middle, and a statue of Vishnu in the other corner of the taps. This also reflects that both the king and the people of Dolakha had liberal religious sentiments at that time.

It is obvious that Buddhism has been widely propagated and followed in Dolakha since very early times. Although the rulers of Dolakha were Hindus, they used to have equal faith in Buddhism. As mentioned in "The Historical Outline of Dolakha," it seems that Buddhism has been more popular since the time of Indrasingh Dev, the first ruler of Dolakha (1591 B.S.), who was called "Rajadhiraj." There was a feeling of religious coordination in Dolakha even at that time. Evidence found so far indicates that as the business of Dolakha as an independent state with Bhot (Tibet) was thriving, it led to the rapid spread of Buddhism.

Manjushree temple

On the hill of Dolakha called Tilincho, there is a small temple of Manjushree, specially worshipped by Buddhists, in which is a stone idol of Saraswati with four hands. Locals worship the statue, known as Manneswari, as the goddess Saraswati. There are two eyes inscribed in the paduka of Manjushree in front of the idol, as in the Manjushree temple of Kathmandu behind Swayambhu. On the day of Sripanchami, a great crowd of people from Dolakha, both Buddhist and Hindu, gather at that temple to worship the goddess of education and enjoy a picnic. According to a Buddhist myth, Boddhisatwa Manjushree of Mahachin cut off Chobhar and let outflow the water of Kathmandu, which was in the form of a lake.

Panchadan festival

Dolakha also celebrates the Panchadan festival, also known as "Banda Jatra," which is observed annually on the day of Bhadrakrishna Trayodashi in the valley by Buddhist Newars such as Shakya, Bajracharya, and Buddhacharya. The Buddhist devotees set aside a portion of their income and

(The author is a professor of business economics.)

Media's Objectifying Beauty Standards



Ruchi Dhital



> It's disheartening to see filmmakers, who should have moral and social responsibility, getting caught up in toxic masculinity. This leads them to neglect empathy, kindness, and basic human emotions.

"And if you can't touch your woman, wherever you want, and if you can't slap, you can't kiss, you can't use cuss words. I don't see emotions there." These are the words of Sandeep Reddy Vanga. After Arjun Reddy (2017) and Kabir Singh (2019), two films about chain-smoking doctors with anger issues, the director returns with Animal, about a chain-smoking engineer with deep-seated daddy issues.

"Kabir Singh is an ugly, unforgivable ode to misogyny that reinforces every argument surrounding toxic masculinity, featuring a horrendous, self-sabotaging protagonist who doesn't deserve your pity or your time." Movie critics had strong negative reactions to the movie's portrayal of toxic masculinity and misogyny. Nonetheless, the audience who loved and enjoyed this movie had their own defence for it, which goes this way: "Come on, it's just a movie. Don't take it too seriously."

It is often said, "A man is the product of the environment." Mass media is a significant force of communication in modern culture. Everything has a subconscious effect in our mind that might not be realised immediately. Sociologists refer to this as mediated culture, where media reflects and creates the culture. The messages in the media promote not only products but also moods, attitudes, and a sense of what is and is not important. Kabir Singh is a movie that glorifies violence and abuse. Many people started idolising Kabir Singh to the extent that a tiktoker ended up killing an air hostess because she was marrying someone else, resonating with the movie's dialogue saying that "jo mera nahi hosakta usse mein kisi aur kaa hone nahi dunga." This translates to, "What cannot be mine, I won't let that be anyone else's.

Making films is a power, and with power comes responsibility. But directors such as Vanga do not care about the impact that their kind of movies leave on society. They only have one mantra, and that is that violence sells. In the movie Animal, despite the fact that the protagonist is portrayed as the father of a daughter, he mocks the discomfort of menstruation. He tells his wife that it's a man's world. He tells his lover to lick his hand to prove that she loves him. And all of these actions are justified or even glorified. As Aamir Khan had said, "Directors who are not very talented creatively, in creating a story and showing emotions, depend heavily on violence and sex to make their films work."

Along with movies, music videos have also long served as a powerful medium for storytelling and artistic expression. These audiovisual creations, accompanied by catchy tunes, captivate audiences worldwide. Yet, beneath the surface of entertainment lies a troubling undercurrent: the persistent objectification of women within the imagery and narratives. From provocative costumes to suggestive choreography and lyrics laden with innuendo, these portrayals contribute to a culture that has been scrutinised for perpetuating harmful stereotypes and shaping distorted perceptions of femininity.

In every Bollywood song, one item is necessary to attract a larger male audience in the theatres and satisfy their male gaze. The lyrics belittle the women and identify them as mere objects. In the song "Fevicol se," women are compared with Tandoori Murgi, who says that men can gulp alcohol. There's another song called "aa ante amalapuram," in which the puberty of a girl is depicted in such a way: "Umar mero athara hone chali (My age is going to be eighteen), Hata de chhilka u mere dil kaa (Remove the cover of my heart), aa kha le moong phali (Come and eat the peanuts). In this song, subliminally, the girl's virginity is being compared to a peanut shell. Madhuri Dixit had gracefully pulled off the dance in a song, but surely that doesn't change the meaning of the words, which say, "choli k piche kya hai, chunri ke niche kya hai." This translates to, "What's behind the blouse? What's under the scarf?" "Kaddu kategа toh sab pe batega" is something that exceeded its limits. It translates to "Once there is defloration, everyone will get a share." This song actually normalises gang rape and is still enjoyed like nothing.

Nepali songs are no better. When "Ghati bhanda tala ta ramri nai chey" by Arjan Pandey was released in July 2019, the comment section exploded because of the chorus that translates, "She is at least beautiful from the neck down." The lyrics totally describe men's lust for women's bodies, yet people have been enjoying the song over the years. Another such song is "Timi aauchau ki arkai bihe garau," which fuels the stereotype. If a woman stays in her paternal home for a bit longer, then the husband threatens her that he'll marry someone else. "Saali Manparyo" is another popular song that presents the chemistry between a brother-in-law and a sister-in-law. The strange part is that the song with such offensive lyrics is played mostly at wedding ceremonies.

All these songs are easily accessible to all age groups. These songs use metaphors to objectify and sexualize women, which in turn normalises sexual abuse in real life.

"I feel like I've been conditioned to believe that in order to be taken seriously, I need to appear and dress better. My confidence changes when I wear makeup, especially when it comes to dating. Because it is in our tendency to seek beauty." Prashna Bhattarai, a corporate worker, says, "It is disheartening that these unrealistic and objectified versions of beauty shape the perception of 'pretty'."

"This is a cycle; objectification sells, so there's very little motivation to actually change how women are portrayed in their work," she continues. Furthermore, exposure to harmful portrayals, particularly among younger members of the population, lays the groundwork for a liking for similar content. The 'popular' stream provides stuff that sparks disagreement, which we enjoy.

It's disheartening to see filmmakers, who should have moral and social responsibility, getting caught up in toxic masculinity. This leads them to neglect empathy, kindness, and basic human emotions.

(The author is a law student at Kathmandu School of Law.)

FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

December 22nd to 28th, 2023 - D. N. Lohani

ARIES

An entertaining week is in the store. Obstacles from the past will gradually be removed. Opponents will face a difficult period. Pleasant events will occur during the initial phase. Some of you may even enjoy a picnic.

TAURUS

The expenditure level will rise. Try to avoid simple injuries. A health disorder is predicted. The family's health will cause concern. Study will take a progressive course. Don't expect much support from family.

GEMINI

Emerging challenges will make you do extra hard work. The profession will face obstacles. Start and end are good from financial perspectives. Expenditure levels can rise during the mid-portion.

CANCER

Extra expenses will bring extra progress. Regular gains will help consolidate your financial position. You will enjoy gains and progress until Monday. The expenditure level will rise on Tuesday. Celebrations or similar events can occur on Thursday.

LEO

Social prestige will rise. Study will take a progressive course. Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. You will find it difficult to control expenses. Initially, travel-related expenses can occur. Friends and family will cooperate.

VIRGO

The initial two days will contain challenges. Social prestige can degrade due to disputes. Circumstances will improve starting Sunday. You will experience a busy schedule. The profession will yield a return.

LIBRA

Avoid risky ventures on Sunday and Monday. You may have to tackle numerous challenges. Family problems will gradually end. Health disorders are predicted, especially cold-related problems. Periods starting on Wednesday are better.

SCORPIO

Rising expenditures will cause some concern. Lack of support from others can create some problems. The recovery of lent money will take some time. Circumstances will improve starting Thursday. Employees will remain dissatisfied with their progress.

SAGITTARIUS

Fear and confusion can reside within the self. Relocation activity can occur. Friends will provide good support. Progress will be retained in the love and marriage sectors. Study will take a progressive course.

CAPRICORN

A health disorder is predicted and will incur costs. You will make some progress. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. The return from the job will be lower than expectations.

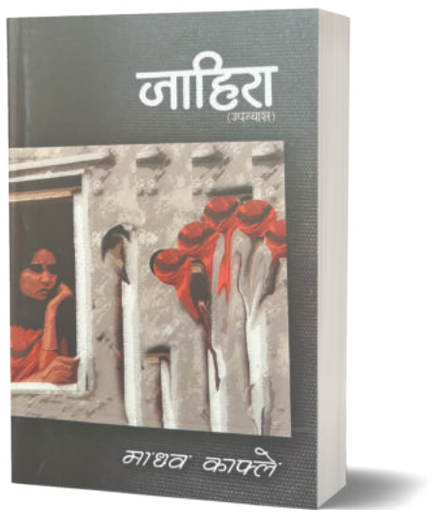
AQUARIUS

Financial status will improve. Investments will generate returns. Travel is probable. Support provided by family will guide you ahead. Study will take a progressive course.

PISCES

An improved week is in store for you. Incomplete assignments from the past will be completed successfully. Short travel is probable. You will be eager to gain new knowledge. Friends and family will cooperate.

Zahira: A Story Of An Unfulfilled Love Wish



BOOK REVIEW



Gandhi Raj Kafle

Zahira, a Nepali novel by Madhav Kafle, published by Amar Tyagi and Junu Chhetri on behalf of Gajal Gund Nepal, price: Rs 250.00, ISBN: 978-9937-9 – 1809 – 1.

Authors often sensibly choose titles for their books using the names of their main characters. This practice effectively stitches these characters into the collective spirit and imaginations of society. Laxmi Prasad Devkota's "Muna-Madan" stands as a masterpiece example in Nepali literature. Here we also have a freshly published book that bears the name of the principal character for the title. Madhav Kafle is the author of the novel titled "Zahira." In fact, this novel, which carries a single-word title, is meaningful because it highlights the central theme of the love story of the principal character, Zahira. However, Zahira, as we know, is not a Hindu girl's name. Yet the story the novelist has shown is that she becomes the true love of a Hindu Nepali man. The novelist demonstrates that the deep and unstoppable power of love causes this phenomenon.

Let us also talk a little about the author. The novelist Madhav Kafle lives in Rautahat District and is contributing to different beats of Nepali literature. And to remember, the essay is his much-loved genre of expression.

However, this time he has forayed into writing a novel under the title "Zahira." What prompted the author to write a story with Muslim themes that was also from Calcutta, India? It may be a question for him. But reasons to guess, too, are there.

In fact, his home place, Rautahat, is also one of the few districts in Nepal where a huge number of Muslim people live, and the city of Calcutta, being a huge city, has been a labour market. Thus, it is natural for the author to choose a Muslim background to write a novel in this city.

Yet the topmost reason for this novel has been the theme of love itself. In fact, love has always been unstoppable in human lives. The cases of inter-cast love and marriage, too, have been increasing for this reason.

In addition to the principal character Zahira, the novel has woven stories with descriptions of the sentiments and behaviours of characters Dibesh, Ekbal, Nadim, Jasmin, Amma Jarina, Punam Sahu, and Dip Bahadur. The main theme of love has expanded with this feature.

The novelist has described some of the known places in Calcutta, India, like Hugli Riverbank, Victoria Memorial, Khidirpur, Sonagachhi, Metro Cinema Hall, etc. Besides public places, he has also mentioned Mussaira-Kabbali traditions of the Muslim community, their way of greetings, their Nikah marriage rituals, etc. This all shows that author Kafle is keen to know about the social practices of Muslim communities for his writing, and the present novel Zahira is his new proof of his passion for literary pursuits.

The novelist has centred the main theme of love between a Muslim girl and a Hindu-Brahmin boy on this background. In fact, this is a kind of silent love. But silent love in the novel sometimes becomes vocal, too. That is why two lovers guess and feel the need to talk about their love for marriage.

This guess is not confined to them only; it is little known to Zahira's guardians', too. But getting nods for girls and boys from guardians is very hard because of two opposite religions and cultures. Some curiosities develop, and one day even Zahira's family prepares to accept the situation if the boy and girl decide to marry.

Meanwhile, Dibesh comes to Nepal, and his return to Calcutta is delayed because of festivals. During this stay, he musters his courage to disclose his love for a Muslim girl, even to invite the family wrath. But fear overcomes courage, and he can't speak even a word about it in the family in Nepal. Finally, he goes to Calcutta, making his courage strong enough to marry Zahira.

> In fact, human stories may not be homogeneous, and there are also many instances where man happens to move towards an undesirable situation. And the merit of literature is that it deals with all situations.

But have time and tide awaited anyone? Zahira's family arranges her marriage, and he has no other alternative but to accept it. The novel's whole story is about the love of a Muslim girl and a Hindu boy, but sadly, it comes to an end after the marriage of Zahira to a man of her own community.

The beauty of this novel lies in the simplicity of the description. Furthermore, bringing traditions and cultures into writing for stories from religiously different communities is also a merit of this novel. In fact, human stories may not be homogeneous, and there are also many instances where man happens to move towards an undesirable situation. And the merit of literature is that it deals with all situations. Madhav Kafle's theme of the novel is in line with this literary pursuit. The author, thus, deserves kudos.

(Kafle is a former Deputy Executive Editor of this daily)

An Inspiring Journey Of A Taekwondo Player



Pramod Joshi

Many people indeed face struggles in their lives. Challenges and problems are a part of everyone's life. However, it is important to learn how to handle them to make a difference. Those who overcome their problems and obstacles are the ones who succeed. They become an inspiration for others and leave a lasting impact.

Ashok Khadka is an excellent example of this. Despite facing several injuries during his career as a Taekwondo player, he persevered and continued to practice the sport. He is now an active coach, referee, and administrator in the domestic Taekwondo scene. For almost two decades, Ashok has been contributing to the promotion of Nepali Taekwondo in various capacities. His dedication and hard work have made him a well-known and respected name in Taekwondo circles.

Injury-plagued career

Unfortunately, Ashok couldn't fulfil his potential in Nepali Taekwondo due to injuries. Injuries are a player's biggest fear, as they can completely derail a player's career. It's not uncommon for players to be forced to retire due to injuries.

In the 2006 South Asian Games (SAG), Ashok was one of the top contenders in the men's under-54 kg weight group. He was in the last three and had a good chance of being selected for the regional sporting fiesta.

However, in a fight with Surendra Shahi, Ashok suffered a severe injury and was unable to complete the game. He had to walkover the match, which was a huge blow to his dreams of playing on the Colombo SAG. Ashok was left with a plaster cast on his leg and had to stay at home. He considers this incident to be the saddest moment of his playing life.

After recovering from his injury, Ashok did not let his spirit dampen and returned to the game. In the following year, he participated in the international taekwondo tournament held in Lucknow, India. However, his left leg got injured again in the quarterfinals. He quickly got his leg plastered and returned to Nepal overnight.

To his dismay, he found out that he had received inadequate treatment in India, with only a plaster applied to his injured leg that was supposed to be operated on. As a result, Ashok had to stay in the hospital for an extended period and the treatment cost him millions of rupees.

Despite the setback, Ashok refused to give up. Although he couldn't compete in Kyorugi, he began working hard in Poomsae, another type of taekwondo. He made a remarkable comeback by winning a gold medal in Poomsae at the sixth National Games held in the Far West. He also went on to win a gold medal in South Korea, demonstrating his unwavering determination and resilience. His recent silver medal feat at the 17th Japan Open International Taekwondo Championships shows his persistent love for Taekwondo.

Successful coach

Ashok has been able to contribute to the world of Taekwondo despite facing setbacks in his sporting career. He has trained more than 450 black belt players and has taught Taekwondo to over 5,000 people.

Ashok's dedication to producing skilled Taekwondo players has also helped to put Nepal on the map in the international Taekwondo community. Moreover, the sixth-dan Taekwondo master wants to fulfil his Olympic dreams through his pupils.

The Nepalese Taekwondo Academy, which he established, could be a catalyst to fulfil his dream. It's truly inspiring to see how Mulpani Dojang's dream project, the Nepalese Taekwondo Academy, has now become a reality with its very own building worth crores.



Competent judge

Ashok's involvement with the Taekwondo jury is truly outstanding. Attending the referee seminar four years ago was a pivotal moment in his taekwondo journey. Being recognised as the best in the seminar by the World Taekwondo Federation made him eligible to become a referee in international competitions. In a short period of time, he has judged over 40 international competitions in various parts of the world. Of them, 36 are world-ranking tournaments.

Ashok was selected as the best judge in the World Taekwondo Championship held in Bulgaria last year. He was also declared the best judge in world-ranking competitions like the Belgium Open, Swedish Open, and Australian Open.

Ashok is one of the few Nepalese taekwondo practitioners who have trained as para referees. Last year, the Ministry of Youth and Sports honoured Ashok as the 'Best Referee' and awarded him a prize of one lakh.

Ashok, who has organised competitions in around twenty-five countries, now has the dream of serving as a judge for the Olympic Games.

In social service

The president of the Kathmandu Taekwondo Association, Ashok, has not limited himself to Taekwondo. He is committed to making a positive impact in his community through social service.

He has been collaborating with Raksha Nepal to provide free taekwondo training to women who have suffered sexual violence. Pooja Bohra, a recipient of this training, went on to win a gold medal in South Korea.

He has extended his support to Chepang, the children of imprisoned parents, and children with various problems by teaching them Taekwondo.

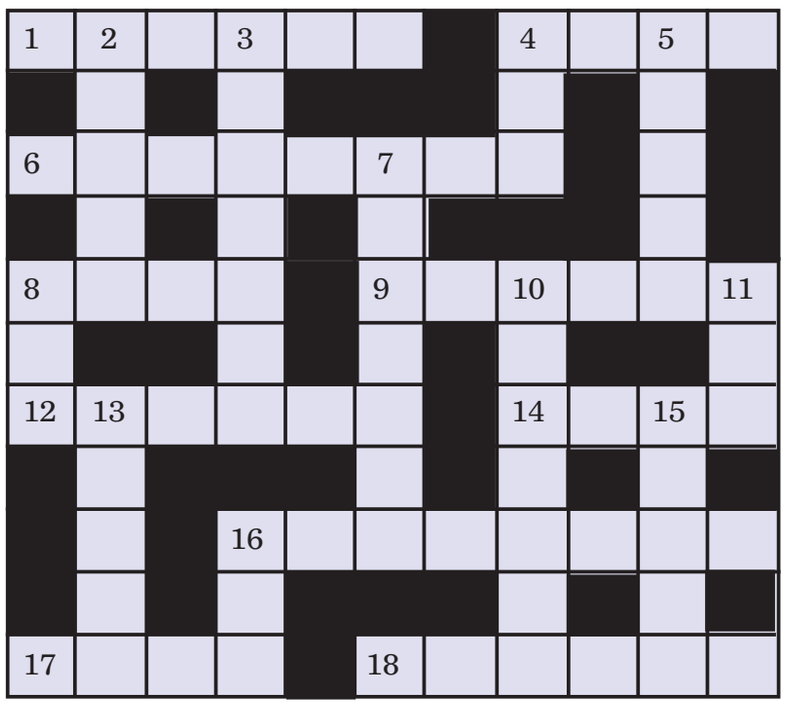
Ashok's contribution during the 2072 earthquake in the Kageshwari area, where he built 14 temporary houses for the victims, highlights his selflessness and willingness to help others in need.

Even during the Corona pandemic, Ashok has provided relief to over 4,000 people and has always lent a helping hand to kidney sufferers, orphans, and disabled people.

Ashok always emphasises that his life's goal is social service. Having undergone in difficult situations himself, he has realised that someone's help in difficult situations can make a life-changing impact. Therefore, he believes in giving back. For him, there is no greater satisfaction than serving others.

(Joshi is Associate Editor at The Rising Nepal.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1771



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
December 27, 2023

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across

1. A safe place of refuge
4. Not occurring very often
6. Junction
8. Snowman
9. Your bodily shape
12. Champion
14. A symbol
16. A poisonous animal like an insect
17. Signal
18. A genre of literature

Down

2. A sudden upward movement
3. Related to women's attraction to another woman
4. Manage fraudulently to gain advantage
5. Allude to
7. Big fire
8. Twist about a vertical axis
10. A partial view
11. A very long period of time
13. A large Madagascan lemur
15. Unpleasant smell
16. Immoral act

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1770

ACROSS: 1. MENACE 4. FAME 6. PETITION 8. STOA 9. PIVOTS 12. CICEROO 14. LAZY 16. PRETASTE 17. FEAT 18. ANONYM

DOWN: 2. EVENT 3. ANIMATE 4. IMPROVE 5. MERIT 7. IMPROVE 8. SAC 10. VOLCANO 11. SPY 13. IMAGE 15. ZITTY 16. PET

LUCKY WINNER

Mana Raja Juju
Smriti Shrestha
Krishna Chandra Gautam

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Khagendra Nath, Sunil Sharma Bhattarai, Rekha Rajopadhyaya, Kumari Nirmala Giri, Kiran Gautam, Surya Shakya, Sheela Shrestha, Bal Krishna Shrestha, Archana Devi Shrestha

CREATIVE CORNER

Timeless Moments Of Digital Camera



Kritaggyaa Bhandari



A digital camera's charm lies in its ability to capture and save brief moments, embodying time's essence. Its mechanical click adds a deep touch, skillfully preserving memories. Unlike a quick swipe on a smartphone, a digital camera requires intent, prompting one to compose the perfect shot. Each snap is a purposeful act, a dance between light and lens, imprinting emotions onto a digital canvas. The tangible hum of the lens's focus and the satisfying snap of the shutter creates a nostalgic symphony. Pixels create stories, turning digital cameras into time machines and bringing back cherished moments. Despite fast technology, the love persists, showing that in pixels, there's enduring magic in capturing bits of our lives.

I grew up using a digital camera, a gadget from a time before everyone had smartphones. My dad bought it from another country, spending his hard-earned money out of curiosity. Over the years, my phone's camera became better, and the digital camera ended up being forgotten.

Now, surprisingly, I feel nostalgic for that outdated technology. Even though iPhones have perfect cameras, their sameness bores me, making me long for the inconvenience of old cameras. The bulky batteries, different memory cards, and complicated photo transfer methods make me feel sorry for these rejected gadgets. Reviving them becomes a labour of love. Maybe it's a shared feeling among people my age, or perhaps it's the pixelation that creates a unique connection between reality and playback, drawing me back to these old devices despite the ever-changing trends.

I love making short films with my camera and creating a video collage afterwards. My creative process involves capturing the nuances of my surroundings and expressing my unique perspective through diverse elements. I don't have any specific criteria for what I'm going to shoot.

I shoot and capture things that people usually don't notice. I sometimes film the graceful fluttering of butterflies in gardens, and sometimes I focus on the intricate chaos of tangled electric wires. My lens seeks to immortalise the overlooked. I also film all the birds chirping together and capture reflections of the sun, shadows, or any random things around me. I believe beauty isn't always in a particular thing. I believe that beauty is everywhere in everything. There is a deep connection between how we pursue things and how we look. Embracing the world through a camera lens is more than a hobby; it's a passionate journey. Each click captures not just images but a visual poetry of emotions, frozen in time.

The dance between light and lens becomes a symphony, echoing the enduring magic of freezing life's fragments. This artistry transforms the camera from a device into a companion, revealing the profound beauty hidden in the simplicity of every captured moment. Many youngsters nowadays engage in unproductive pursuits like excessive internet use and prolonged video gaming, negatively impacting their mental well-being.

Instead of solely focusing on capturing moments through a camera, consider embracing the beauty in the small things around you. By taking time to appreciate the often-overlooked aspects of life, individuals can delve into profound questions about existence, purpose, and human connections. Exploring such inquiries, even if they touch on conspiracy theories, can be a genuinely productive endeavor. While my passion lies in recording videos and capturing photos, you may discover your sources of peace and joy in alternative activities. Now is the moment to prioritise both self-discovery and appreciation for the world around you.

I discovered how much I love taking pictures because I enjoy capturing little moments around me. Instead of spending too much time on the internet and scrolling endlessly, I decided to focus on making videos with cameras. This brings me a lot of happiness. Filmmaking isn't just a hobby; it's a beautiful and meaningful passion that is a big part of my creative journey.

I hope more people can enjoy the simple happiness of taking pictures of all the little things in their lives. This way, they can create a lovely collection of memories that goes beyond just digital pictures.

It shows the beauty of moments that don't last very long. It's like freezing a moment in time. Using a camera isn't just about taking pictures; it's about paying close attention to the world around you. Each photo becomes a part of your own story, making a picture book of your life.

This collection isn't just on a computer or phone; it's real; you can touch it. It's like a scrapbook of your feelings and experiences. So, I hope that more people can enjoy this simple joy, finding beauty in the short and sweet moments of life.

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Dharan-16 Sunsari, Nepal

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-403

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 406 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 34 to 82 between. The number should not be used twice.

	72		34		52	
	80		42		60	
	39		50		68	
46		57		75		37
54		65		76		45
		73		35		53

75	84	93	46	55	64	73
83	92	52	54	63	72	74
91	51	53	62	71	80	82
50	59	61	70	79	81	90
58	60	69	78	87	89	49
66	68	77	86	88	48	57
67	76	85	94	47	56	65

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-402

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